The Sermon on the Mount

and

The Gospel of the Grace of God

CR Stam

THE SERMON
ON THE MOUNT

and

THE GOSPEL
OF THE GRACE OF GOD

by

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Above all, we thank God for insight given in the study of our Lord's great Sermon on the Mount, and for His help in putting our thoughts into words.

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Kindness of Timothy Galusha

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PREFACE

While the type was being set for our commentary on the *Pastoral Epistles* of Paul (with all the proofreading and editing involved) the author typed up and refined notes he had made for *Bible Time* broadcasts aired some time ago. The result is the present volume; *The Sermon on the Mount* and *The Gospel of the Grace of God.*

This book is not an exhaustive consideration of our Lord's sermon, nor a verse-by-verse commentary on its contents. Rather it is a *dispensational* study intended to help the reader to place the Sermon on the Mount just where it belongs in the program of God and so to *understand* it the better and *enjoy* it the more - especially as we compare it with what God has given to *us* under grace.

Some have endeavored to show that precepts found in the Sermon on the Mount are also found in Paul's epistles. Of course! This could be said of many parts of the Old Testament, but this does not make the Sermon on the Mount God's message or program for *today.*

In discussing the details of this great sermon we aim at the simple, sincere reader. We do not spend time, for example, with such matters as the cutting off of the hand, the plucking out of the eye or the "beam," or log, in the "critic's" eye, for we are convinced that the ordinary reader will immediately recognize these terms as figures of speech for how, for example, could a log fit into a human eye?

Thus it is our aim, in this volume, to get at the *sense* of our Lord's words, often comparing them with the great heavenly truths which, from His glory at the Father's right hand, He later revealed to, and through, the Apostle Paul. May the result bring light and blessing to many a reader.

-Cornelius R. Stam

Chicago, Illinois
March 15, 1983

INTRODUCTION

It appears that in certain areas the New Evangelicalism has brought us around again to the old time Modernism. Like the Modernists of fifty to a hundred years ago, many church leaders today keep hammering away at the Sermon on the Mount and the gospel of the kingdom because these have so much to say about peace, non-resistance, social justice, sharing the wealth, etc. This they call "the social gospel."

We cannot, and do not, question that the Sermon on the Mount contains the very words of the Lord Jesus Christ, and that they were all binding *at that time,* but we hold that later our Lord, from His glory in heaven, suspended that program until a future day, raising up Paul, the chief of sinners saved by grace, to usher in a new dispensation, specifically named *"the dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:1-3), and that to him was committed *"the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24), the gospel which we are to proclaim today.

Sir Winston Churchill is reported to have said on one occasion: "What a happy world this would be if we all lived according to the Sermon on the Mount!" But it has been historically demonstrated that, due to the depravity of human nature, man can no more practice the Sermon on the Mount consistently than he can consistently obey the Ten Commandments. Nor will he be able so to live until the Holy Spirit *takes control* and *causes* him to do so. Thus God promised His people Israel:

"And I will put My Spirit within you, and *cause* you to walk in My statutes, and ye *shall* keep My judgments and *do* them.

"And ye shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers; and ye shall be My people, and I will be your God" (Ezek. 36:27,28).

Here is where many modern Bible teachers have gone astray. They look upon the Bible merely as a book from which we may glean many beautiful thoughts and precepts. They do not see that it contains *a line of teaching* progressively, or historically, unfolded. This is why in our day special attention should be given to II Tim. 2:15:

"Study to show thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the Word of truth."[1]

According to this important passage of holy writ, God's workmen will have reason to be *ashamed* and will fail of God's approval if they fail to give unremitting care[2]

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[1] It is not without significance that in the same brief letter in which Paul declares that "all Scripture" is God-inspired and "profitable," he emphasizes the importance of "rightly dividing" it (II Tim. 3:16; 2:15).

[2] The word here rendered "study" (Gr., *spoudazo)* has the sense of *painstaking effort,* and the term "rightly dividing" (Gr., *orthotomeo), to cut straight.*

to "rightly divide" His Word.

Sometimes we are too careless in discussing the Holy Scriptures. We speak in broad generalities where the Scriptures are specific, or conversely, we insist on specific interpretations where the Scriptures speak in generalities. The writer has before him an article titled, *Is the Sermon on the Mount For the Church?* There are two things wrong with this title. Of course the Sermon on the Mount is *for* the Church. *All* Scripture is God-inspired *and profitable.* How many *blessed truths,* how many *precious lessons,* then, we may learn from the *Sermon on the Mount!*

But while all Scripture is *for* us, it was not all written *about us* or addressed *to us.* Our private mail, so to speak, is found in the Epistles of Paul, God's appointed apostle for the present dispensation.

Certainly we must distinguish between *Peter* who, at Pentecost, addressed the "men of Israel" and "all the house of Israel" (Acts 2:22,36), and *Paul* who wrote in Rom. 11:13:

"I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles. I magnify mine office."

But there is more: This title reads, "Is the Sermon on the Mount for *the Church?"* A bit of study will reveal that the word "church" (Gr. *ekklesia)* means simply a called-out assembly, and God has always had His called-out people. In Acts 7:38 Israel is called "the church in the wilderness." Later, in Matt. 18:17, when Christ on earth gave instructions concerning the unreasonable brother, He said, "If he shall neglect to hear them, *tell it unto the Church."* Still later, at Pentecost, men and women were *"added to the church,"* as we read in Acts 2:47. Thus God had his Church in Old Testament times, and when our Lord walked this earth, and at Pentecost (when some contend the Church *began*!).

If thus asked more correctly, the answer can only be an emphatic *No.* And this is what we will, by the grace of God, demonstrate in this volume. In a word, it is our purpose to show the *difference* between the Sermon on the Mount and the gospel of the grace of God.

By no means do we desire to rob God's people of this precious part of His Word. Indeed, the Sermon on the Mount will prove *the more blessed* to us as we learn *where it fits into the program of God.*

Chapter I

THE SERMON ON THE MOUNT and PROGRESSIVE REVELATION

Some have entertained the notion that we make much of Paul's epistles because we simply *prefer* his teachings, or because in the records of our Lord's ministry and the book of Acts there are passages which we find difficult to accept or obey. This, they say, is why we teach that the Sermon on the Mount does not comprise God's program for today. This is not correct.

It is rather because we recognize in the Bible a system of doctrine, a line of teaching, a progressive, historical revelation. We recognize the divine principle enunciated in Isa. 28:9,10:

"Whom shall He teach knowledge, and whom shall He make to understand doctrine? them that are weaned from the milk, and drawn from the breasts.

"For precept must be upon precept; precept upon precept, line upon line, line upon line; here a little, and there a little."

This is God's method of teaching and, in fact, our own. Not all at once, but "precept upon precept, line upon line, here a little and there a little," God has revealed Himself to man. Noah knew more about God than Adam had known. Abraham knew more than Noah, Moses than Abraham, David than Moses, the twelve apostles than David, and Paul knew more than the twelve and all that had gone before, for to him was revealed the very "secret of the gospel," *the capstone of divine revelation.* (See Eph. 3:1-4; 3:8,9; 6:18-20).

Comparing Exodus or Matthew with Ephesians, for example, it is evident that God has dealt differently with men of different ages, according to their knowledge of Himself. There has been *development* and *progress,* historically, in the knowledge of God and His purposes. The whole teaching of Scripture works up, as it were, - to the revelation of the mystery, or secret, made known through Paul.

This, in a word, is *dispensationalism:* the systematic and historical consideration of the revealed Word of God. And such a consideration *must* lead to the conclusion that the Sermon on the Mount does *not* comprise God's program for the present day, but is rather the charter of the Messianic kingdom, over which our Lord will one day reign.

A recognition of this fact will reveal that there is no contradiction between the Sermon on the Mount and Paul's epistles. There are only contradictions if we

apply them to the *same* dispensation.

In later chapters we will deal with some *seeming* contradictions between the Sermon on the Mount and the epistles of Paul, but we may rest assured that God *would not* contradict Himself. Those who think He does, are forced to this conclusion only because they have not observed the principle of progressive revelation.

Let us consider briefly the subject of the Messianic kingdom, for example: (1) The kingdom was PROMISED in Old Testament times (Jer. 23:5). (2) It was PROCLAIMED AT HAND during our Lord's earthly ministry (Matt. 4:17). (3) It was OFFERED at Pentecost, *after* the death and resurrection of Christ (Acts 3:19-21). (4) It was REJECTED as the book of Acts shows (Acts 7:54-8:3; 28:25-28). (5) It was POSTPONED[3] and is being held in abeyance until a future time (Matt. 23:39; Rom. 11:25). (6) Finally, when our Lord returns to judge and reign, the kingdom will be ESTABLISHED on earth (Rom. 11:26). *Then,* for the first time since the fall of man, this world will become a scene of true peace, prosperity and blessing.

The establishment of the kingdom of Christ on earth is the very goal of Old Testament prophecy, but the epistles of Paul explain how the prophetic program was interrupted by grace. Thus the true condition of this world today can be understood only as we recognize progressive revelation in Scripture.

Those who recognize the truth of the mystery revealed to Paul do not need to "spiritualize" plain predictions of prophecy, but those who fail, or refuse to recognize it are forced to "spiritualize" much of the Old Testament. They see how prophecy was steadily fulfilled right through the resurrection of Christ and Pentecost, but then its fulfillment evidently ceased. The Tribulation and the signs of Christ's return did not appear, nor did He return to reign. So their explanation is that the early persecutions of Christianity evidently constituted the prophesied Tribulation and that Christ is reigning today over "spiritual" Israel, the Body of Christ. But actually this is not "spiritualizing" the Scriptures; it is arbitrarily *altering* them, and such perversions of the clear Word of God not only violate the Word itself; they compound the confusion which already exists in the Church, and stand condemned by God.

One Bible commentator has said: "All parts of the Bible; the whole counsel of God, are sufficiently important to the people of God of all ages to investigate." Think of it! *All* parts of the Bible sufficiently important to the people of God of *all ages* to investigate!

How, pray tell, could Abraham investigate the Law of Moses? How could Moses investigate the Sermon on the Mount? How could those who heard that sermon investigate the book of Acts or Paul's epistles? This alone shows the significance

[3] A *planned* postponement, of course.

of the *fact* of *progressive revelation* and emphasizes the *importance* of *dispensational Bible study.*

And studying the Bible in this way, where do *we* fit in? What is God's spiritual message and program for us today? We fit in between the final rejection of Christ and His kingdom, and the coming Tribulation and His return to earth to judge and reign.

Not wishing to judge this rebellious world immediately, God *saved* Saul of Tarsus, the chief of sinners, our Lord's bitterest enemy on earth, and sent him forth as His ambassador, to offer peace and reconciliation to His enemies, proclaiming salvation by grace to all who would trust the rejected Christ and acknowledge Him as Lord and Savior.

This is why the legalism, the call for social reform, communal living, etc., of the Sermon on the Mount, is entirely missing from Paul's epistles. Instead they are full of what the Lord Jesus Christ has done for *poor lost sinners;* full of gracious offers of "the exceeding riches of [God's] grace" in blessing believers "with *all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ"* (Eph. 1:3).

CHRIST ON EARTH AND CHRIST IN HEAVEN

It is a sad fact of our times that many people today are not interested in the Bible largely because so few Christians are interested enough to study it deeply. Yet, when rightly divided, we find the Scriptures more relevant than ever to our circumstances and our needs.

One result of this lack of interest is that it is not generally understood that the Lord Jesus proclaimed one message while on earth and quite another after His rejection here and His ascension to heaven.

While on earth He proclaimed what is called *"the gospel of the kingdom"* (Matt. 4:23; *et al).* This kingdom was to be - and will be - established on earth and would produce a way of life that would bring peace and prosperity and blessing to all mankind. Our Lord enunciated the principles of this kingdom in His *Sermon on the Mount.*

But as we have seen, the King and His kingdom were rejected and our Lord, in amazing grace, *saved* Saul of Tarsus and sent him forth as the Apostle Paul, to proclaim *"the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24).

Never do we find Paul offering the kingdom to Israel - nor *could* he have done so, for such an offer would have had to be made at Jerusalem, from whence our Lord had ordered him to *depart immediately* when he had first returned to the city after his conversion (See Acts 22:17-21).

Thus Paul was sent to the Gentiles by the glorified Lord, to proclaim a message of *"grace and peace,"* a message which differed greatly from *"the gospel of the kingdom,"* which our Lord had proclaimed while on earth.

Thus the claim that the so-called" great commission" contains our Lord's "last words" is an error, for He spoke *again* from His glory in heaven, to and through the Apostle Paul (Here the reader should carefully examine I Cor. 11:23; 15:3; II Cor. 13:2,3; Gal. 1:11,12; Eph. 3:3).

The reason we emphasize this is because some pose the question: "Whose words are the more important, those of Christ or those of Paul?" overlooking the fact that Paul's words *were* the words of Christ from His glory in heaven. These words, not those of the so-called "great commission," were His *latest* words - words of mercy and grace for "this present evil age."

This is the glorious message which God has now committed to us, variously called *"the preaching of the cross"* (I Cor. 1:18), *"the gospel of the glory of Christ"* (II Cor. 4:4), *"the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24) and *"My [Paul's] gospel, and the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery, which was kept secret since the world began, but now is made manifest.* . ." (Rom. 16:25,26).

We should not leave this subject without reminding our readers that our Lord wrote no book. Thus His words recorded by Paul are no less inspired or authentic than those recorded by Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, and it is most important to bear in mind that while the four so-called "evangelists" recorded His words spoken *while on earth,* Paul proclaimed the message of grace which He committed to him later, *from His glory in heaven.*

Chapter II

THE SERMON ON THE MOUNT and THE LAW OF MOSES

To understand the *Sermon on the Mount* we should bear in mind that our Lord, while on earth, was, and taught His disciples to be, *subject to the Law of Moses.* In Matt. 23:2,3 we find Him saying:

"... The scribes and the Pharisees sit in Moses' seat:[4]

"All therefore whatsoever they bid you observe, that observe and do...."

THE LAW EXPANDED AND MADE MORE BINDING

The scribes and Pharisees had added many fine points and detailed instructions to the Law of Moses, making it even more difficult to fulfill. Yet they occupied Moses' place as the leaders of Israel, and they were to be obeyed. This clearly indicates that the covenant of the Law (Ex. 19:5,6) had not yet been abolished. Indeed, the principles of the kingdom as found in the Sermon on the Mount transcend those of the Law of Moses and even of the additional rules and regulations added by the scribes and Pharisees. Thus our Lord said:

"For I say unto you, That except your righteousness shall exceed the righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees, ye shall in no case enter into the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 5:20).

Again and again in the Sermon on the Mount we find such words as the following: "It hath been said unto you. . . *but I say unto you.* . . ." For example, in Matt. 5:21,22 we read:

"Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, thou shalt not kill, and whosoever shall kill shall be in danger of the judgment.

"But I say unto you, that whosoever is *angry* with his brother without a cause shall be in danger of the judgment."

And again in Vers. 27, 28:

"Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not commit adultery, but I say unto you that whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her

[4] i.e., they occupy Moses' position. The word "seat," here is *kathedra,* denoting a seat, or chair, of authority.

hath committed adultery with her already in his heart."

And so on in case after case our Lord quotes the Law of Moses, or the general teachings about the Law and then sets an even higher standard, judging the very motives of the heart.

Clearly, then, "the fulness of the time," referred to by Paul in Gal. 3:13 and 4:4,5, had not yet come, for rather than redeeming His hearers from what Paul calls "the curse of the law," our Lord made His precepts and prohibitions even more searching and binding. And this for a very good reason. It was meant to impress further upon men their depraved condition and the impossibility of their rendering perfect obedience to God - hence their deep need of a Savior. As with the Law, the Sermon on the Mount taught its greatest lesson *historically.* It demonstrated that man needs Christ, not first as a King to reign over him and show him a felicitous way of life, but as a *Savior* to pay the penalty for his sins and deliver him from the judgment to come.

We freely concede to the preachers of the "social gospel" that the Sermon on the Mount teaches good government, good human relations, and good conduct in general, but it does not deal with the utter impossibility of fallen man achieving this goal,[5] human nature being what it is. The time for this had not yet come.

But will human nature ever change? Will such happy relations as described in the Sermon on the Mount ever actually exist? Yes, they will, when Christ returns to earth to reign.

THE LAW IN THE KINGDOM

It is in connection with the coming Messianic kingdom that the *"new covenant* with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah" will be fulfilled (Jer. 31:31-34; Ezek. 36:24-28). According to the terms of this covenant God says to His erring people:

"And I will put My spirit within you, and *cause* you to walk in My statutes, and ye *shall* keep My judgments *and do them"* (Ezek. 36:27).

When this promise is fulfilled, Israel will be so richly blessed that the blessing will flow to all nations, and the nations, in response will "flow" to "the Lord's house" in Jerusalem (Isa. 2:2).

"And many people shall go and say, Come ye, and let us go up to the mountain of the Lord, to the house of the God of Jacob; and He will teach us of His ways, and we will walk in His paths: for out of Zion shall go forth the law, and the word of the Lord from Jerusalem" (Isa. 2:3).

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[5] Nor, generally, do the preachers of the "social gospel. "

Three great changes will have taken place in connection with our Lord's return that will greatly facilitate godly behavior on the part of man. The *world,* the *flesh* and the *devil,* man's three great enemies, will then have been brought under Messiah's control.

As to the *world,* we read concerning that day:

"The kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord and of His Christ; and He shall reign for ever and ever" (Rev. 11:15).

Thus it will then be *good* to be worldly. The *world* will be good. It will be *His* world.

As to "the flesh," we know that during the kingdom reign of Christ sickness will be abolished (Isa. 35:3-6) and *"the child shall die being an hundred years old,"* and *if* he dies it will be because he has been cursed for some sin (Isa. 65:20). The thought evidently is that one dying at one hundred years of age will be considered a mere child, for with the Great Healer among them men will not need to die. With the human body thus strengthened, it will be much easier to withstand temptation. But - *temptation?* Not only will the world now be a *good* world and the flesh brought under control, but the devil will be bound in the abyss:

" And he laid hold on the dragon, that old serpent, which is the Devil, and Satan, and bound him a thousand years,

"And cast him into the bottomless pit, and shut him up, and set a seal upon him, that he should deceive the nations no more, till the thousand years should be fulfilled. . ." (Rev. 20:2,3).

Think how much easier it will be to do what is right and good, when the world, the flesh, and the devil are all thus brought under Messiah's control!

And all this *will* take place when our Lord returns to reign. Godless men may laugh and sneer at the very idea of Christ's return to this earth, but we can brook their sneers. Common sense, as well as the Word of God, tells us that God will not leave this world forever a scene of trouble and misery and oppression and greed and hate and intrigue and violence and marching armies and sickness and sorrow and death. It will not always be a scene of hospitals and mental institutions and prisons. No! Our Lord Jesus Christ, who preached the Sermon on the Mount only to be rejected and crucified, will return in power and glory, and the precepts of that Sermon will be fulfilled, with the most blessed way of life prevailing.

THE SERMON AND PENTECOST

But apart from the common sense and Bible predictions God has given us a *demonstration* of these blessed things to come. At Pentecost the Holy Spirit *took possession* of the disciples, for we read that they were *"baptized"* and *"filled"* with the Holy Spirit when the Day of Pentecost had fully come (Acts 1:5; 2:1,4). The results: not only did they begin speaking with tongues and working miraculous signs, but they began spontaneously living the Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount.

In the first chapters of the Book of Acts it is impossible to find a sin, a blunder or even a mistake among the disciples. They all lived for the Lord and for each other - *spontaneously.* In Acts 4:32, when the number of the disciples had grown to "about five thousand men" alone (perhaps 30 to 40 thousand with the women and children) we read:

" And the multitude of them that believed were of one heart and of one soul: neither said any of them that aught of the things which he possessed was his own; but they had all things common."

Think of it! Has there been any period of time during "this present evil age" when five thousand, or five hundred, or fifty, or even five believers were *completely* of one accord? The fact is that today not even two people can be completely of one accord in everything unless one of them is mentally incompetent and slavishly follows the other. Yet here were five thousand men (perhaps 30-40 thousand people) so completely "of one heart and of one soul" that none of them said that anything he had was his own, but they had all things common. They truly lived for each other.

As we have seen, however, the King and His kingdom were again rejected by the favored nation,[6] so that *this* operation of the Holy Spirit ceased. Soon the record shows the disciples failing and stumbling again, as the most sincere believers do today.

This brief Pentecostal period, then, was a foretaste of the Millennial kingdom, given in conjunction with the apostles' *offer* of the return of Christ if Israel would but repent (Acts 3:19-21).

But let us return to our Lord and His disciples as He preached the Sermon on the Mount, for our Lord closed His sermon with a challenge and a warning, to show how fully binding His words were upon His hearers. The language is clear, and it is strong. The principles and precepts of the Sermon on the Mount are not to be taken lightly. Those who hear *and do* what He commands will, He says, be like a house built upon a rock and will stand through the storms to come, but those who hear but *do not* obey His commands will be like a house built on the sand and

[6] Even in the face of this impressive demonstration of kingdom blessing

their ruin will be complete (Matt. 7:24-27).

This stern warning indicates how great an error it is to suppose, as some do, that we can live by the Sermon on the Mount in a general sort of way and yet *disobey* many of its specific precepts.

It has been said, for example, that we should be *willing* to obey our Lord's commands to sell all our earthly belongings and give them to the poor *should He ask us to do this!* But our Lord *did* direct His disciples to do this, not only in the Sermon on the Mount, but again and again in His preaching of "the gospel of the kingdom." Yet those ~ who preach the" social gospel" from the Sermon on the Mount do not obey this injunction. Many do not even dare to preach this part of the Sermon. They simply take two aspirin tablets, as it were, and try to forget about it. But our Lord closed His Sermon with the stern warning: "Obey or perish," a warning which our "social gospel" preachers should heed.

RIGHTLY DIVIDING THE WORD

How important, then, to obey II Tim. 2:15 and understand what the Sermon on the Mount teaches above all. What good does it do to tell a condemned sinner to be good and do good according to the Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount? First, he is "condemned already" (Rom. 3:19; John 3:18), and second, his depraved nature keeps him from being good or doing anything that can please God (Rom. 8:8).

Rather we must proclaim the glorious message sent to sinful men by the ascended, glorified Lord. We must tell how *"Christ hath redeemed us from the curse of the law, being made a curse for us"* (Gal. 3:13). We must tell how He has paid the full penalty for our sins, utterly robbing Satan and the Law of their claims against us. This is *"the gospel of the grace of God,"* first committed to the Apostle Paul and now to us.

After the Law was given by Moses, and its standards raised even higher by the Lord Jesus Christ, our Lord went to Calvary and nailed the Law to the cross (Col. 2:14), and now - *what a difference!*

"But now, the righteousness of God WITHOUT THE LAW is manifested. . ." (Rom. 3:21).

"[We] declare, I say, at this time, HIS [Christ's] righteousness, that [God] might be just and [at the same time] the justifier of him which believeth in Jesus" (Rom. 3:26).

Mark well, under the "Great Commission" to the eleven it was, "He that believeth *and is baptized* shall be saved" (Mark 16:16), and Peter, working under this commission at Pentecost commanded his convicted hearers:

"Repent, and be baptized, everyone of you, in the name of Jesus Christ *for the remission of sins. . .*" (Acts 2:38).

But here, in Rom. 3:26, water baptism is not required for the remission of sins. Now God proclaims *Christ's righteousness* for the remission of sins, "that He might be just," yet "the justifier of *him which believeth in Jesus" - Period!* Blessed sentence ending! Wondrous grace!

Chapter III

MATTHEW 5 AND ROMANS 5
THE LAW AND THE PROPHETS

In Matt. 5:17 our Lord clearly stated His objective in preaching the Sermon on the Mount:

"Think not that I am come to destroy the Law or the prophets; I am not come to destroy, but to fulfill."

It is true that our Lord fulfilled the Law for us law-breakers[7] in a two-fold way: He perfectly obeyed the Law in His life and He died as a law-breaker, paying the penalty of the broken Law for us in His death. However, we do not believe that our Lord had this in mind when He said that he had not come to destroy, but to fulfill the Law and the prophets.

1. It is not until much later, in Matt. 16:21, that we read:

"From that time forth, began Jesus to show unto His disciples how that He must go unto Jerusalem, and suffer. . . and be killed, and be raised again the third day." Thus, in our Lord's Sermon on the Mount He could hardly have been speaking of His coming death for sin. Nor should we read Paul's God-given doctrine of imputed righteousness into the Sermon on the Mount, for we are clearly told that when Jesus *began* to tell His disciples about His coming death and resurrection, Peter *rebuked* Him for thinking He would be killed (Matt. 16:22), and *none* of the twelve understood what He was even talking about (Luke 18:34).

2. Here in Matt. 5:17 our lord states that He had come to fulfill the Law *and the prophets.* This corresponds to the message which He and His apostles had been preaching: "the gospel of *the kingdom."* This kingdom, so long prophesied and so graphically described in the Old Testament Scriptures, will be based upon the principles and precepts of the Sermon on the Mount, which in turn was based upon the Mosaic Law.

Thus, when our Lord reigns as King, and His subjects follow the principles of the Sermon on the Mount, the Law and the prophets will be fulfilled. Not only will God have "put the law within their hearts," so that they will spontaneously obey it, but the glorious descriptions of Messiah's reign, called by Peter, *"the times of refreshing,"* will also be fulfilled.

We repeat, this will take place only when Messiah reigns and the Holy Spirit *takes control* of His people and *causes* them to do His will, as we have seen from Ezek. 36:27. How very erroneous, then, to make the theme of our Lord's Sermon

[7] Rom. 2:15 and the latter part of Rom. 3:19 expose the error of the teaching that the Law of Moses does not *affect* the Gentiles.

the theme of our message to mankind today! What folly to suppose that this will be a better world if we just tell people what they ought to do and how they ought to live!

It is true that the Sermon on the Mount advocates humility, righteousness, mercy, purity, peace, patience, forgiveness and everything that is good. It urges those who are persecuted to turn the other cheek. It urges all who are blessed with material goods to share their belongings with others, to love their enemies, not to be concerned about the morrow, to seek first the kingdom of God, etc. Thus if the Sermon on the Mount were obeyed this would indeed be a better world to live in. But, apart from *one brief period of time* (at Pentecost), when Christ's followers were *"baptized"* in the Holy Spirit and *"filled"* with the Holy Spirit (Acts 1:5; 2:4), these admonitions have failed to produce the desired results, and the reason for this is found in the epistles of Paul where we learn the great truth of *"the mystery,"* the secret, *"hid from ages and from generations, but now. . . made manifest to His saints"* (Col. 1:26).

Let us then turn from Matthew 5 to Romans 5.

ROMANS 5

In Rom. 5:12 the Apostle points out that:

"... by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned."

Thus man's problem is not one of environment, but of *heredity.* He is not a sinner because he sins; he sins because he is a sinner - *by birth, by nature.* We could take any segment of this world's population and put them into the most favorable environment - if this were possible - but they would turn out no better, for sin is in our very nature.

How often we see the natures of parents in their children and their grandchildren! Sometimes parents ask, "Why does Johnny disobey and cause us so much trouble?" The answer is simple: "Because he is *your son."*

What we seek to emphasize is a fact that by now should be perfectly obvious: that preaching of the Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount will not change mankind, simply because man, in his fallen condition, is *bad,* not good. This is what self-righteous man denies, but God's Word insists upon, and it is amply confirmed by personal observation and the news media.

In the same fifth chapter of Romans - as in all of his epistles, the apostle Paul proclaims the wonderful message of grace to which we have referred.

Three times in Romans 5 we read that Christ died for fallen man. Speaking

historically of the human race, the Apostle says first:

"When we were yet *without strength,* in due time Christ died for the ungodly" (5:6).

Thus, Christ died for us in our *helplessness,* utterly unable as we were to save ourselves from sin and its consequences. But why does this passage label the unsaved man *"ungodly"?* We can almost hear some unsaved reader protest: "I am not an *ungodly* person. I go to church, I pray and even read the Bible." But may the author respond to this reader in this way: Suppose I should introduce you to a friend, and say to him, "I want you to meet my friend here. He's a very godly man." Would you not be embarrassed? Why? Because you know in your heart that you are *not* godly, and if you are not godly are you not *ungodly?* And should you not accept the good news that Christ died for the ungodly?

Further, the Apostle declares:

"But God commendeth His love toward us in that while we were yet *sinners* Christ died for us" (5:8).

Thus Christ died for us in our *sinfulness.*

What a vast difference between the Ten Commandments and the gospel of the grace of God! In Ex. 20:6, in the record of the Ten Commandments, God promises to "show mercy unto thousands of them *that love Me, and keep My commandments,"* but here in Rom. 5:8 we are assured that "God commendeth His love toward us in that *while we were yet sinners Christ died for us."* What infinite love; what boundless grace!

Finally, in Rom. 5:10 the Apostle takes us even farther:

". . . when we were *enemies* we were reconciled to God by the death of His Son."

How beautiful! In our *helplessness,* in our *sinfulness,* yes, even in our *wilfulness* and *rebellion,* "Christ died for us," and sent Paul, himself the chief of sinners, saved by grace, to proclaim an amnesty, offering peace and reconciliation to His enemies on the basis of the blood shed at Calvary.

How appropriate, then, are the closing verses of Romans 5!

"Moreover, the law entered that the offense might abound. But where sin abounded, *grace did much more abound:*

"That as sin hath reigned unto death, EVEN SO MIGHT GRACE REIGN THROUGH RIGHTEOUSNESS UNTO ETERNAL LIFE, BY JESUS CHRIST OUR LORD" (Rom. 5:20,21).

During the kingdom reign of Christ, when the Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount are fulfilled, *righteousness* will reign. But now, though the days are evil and godlessness abounds, though righteousness is trampled upon and Christ remains an exile, *GRACE REIGNS!* And this not through leniency or laxity, but *"through righteousness,"* i.e. the righteousness of Christ in *paying the penalty* for our sins, so that it is now a righteous thing on God's part to justify the believing sinner: *"that He might be just, and the justifier of him that believeth in Jesus"* (Rom. 3:26).

Chapter IV

THE BEATITUDES

While many of our Lord's statements in the Sermon on the Mount may be, wholly or in part, applied to us today, the sermon clearly does not contain *"the gospel of the grace of God"* or comprise the program for the Body of Christ, the Church of today. It belongs rather to "the gospel of the kingdom," which our Lord and His disciples were proclaiming with His reign over Israel in view. It will be gloriously fulfilled when He returns to earth to occupy His rightful place on the throne of David (Jer. 23:5; Luke 1:32,33).

It is a sad fact that many leaders of the professing Church have unwittingly helped to lead the Church, our country and the world into their present confusion and unrest by failing to rightly divide the Word of truth and by preaching the Sermon on the Mount and the Beatitudes as though the Lord were addressing them to us. These leaders should rather be proclaiming "the mystery" which later, from His glory in heaven, our Lord committed to Paul and to us in connection with "the dispensation of the grace of God" (Acts 20:24; Eph. 3:1-4; II Tim. 2:2).

Such should search the Scriptures and see how the Messianic kingdom, *predicted* in the prophetic Word, and proclaimed "at hand" while our Lord was on earth, was actually *offered* by the apostles at Pentecost and then *rejected* by Israel (Jer. 23:5; Matt. 3:1,2; 4:17; 10:5-7; Acts 3:19,20; 7:51-53). Thus the establishment of the kingdom has been held in abeyance until our Lord's return to judge and reign.

It was when Stephen was dragged out of Jerusalem and stoned to death[8] that God, in matchless mercy and love, interrupted the prophetic program and raised up another apostle to usher in a new and unprophesied dispensation: "*the dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:1-4). It was appropriate that the apostle and herald of this new dispensation should be Paul, himself the chief of sinners, saved by grace (I Tim. 1:13-16).

When we take our Bibles and compare the Sermon on the Mount with the Epistles of Paul, observing carefully what each contains and what each does not, we find a wonderful *way of life* on earth proclaimed in the former, but nothing about God's plan of salvation from sin by grace through faith in Christ alone. Conversely, in the latter we find the blessed message of abounding grace to sinners, but nothing about social reform, equal rights, communal living or anything of that sort. The Apostle Paul makes it clear that with the rejection of Christ this world was doomed to judgment, but that God in grace delayed the judgment of Israel and the nations so that individual sinners might find forgiveness and salvation through faith in Christ, who died for our sins.

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[8] Fulfilling our Lord's prediction of Luke 19:14.

"For God hath concluded them all in unbelief, *that He might have mercy upon all.*

"O the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are His judgments, and His ways past finding out!

"For who hath known the mind of the Lord? or who hath been His counsellor?" (Rom. 11:32-34; cf. Eph. 1:1; Rom. 3:24).

THE BEATITUDES

"And He opened His mouth, and taught them, saying,

"Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

"Blessed are they that mourn, for they shall be comforted.

"Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth.

"Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness, for they shall be filled.

"Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy.

"Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God.

"Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called the children of God.

"Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

"Blessed are ye, when men shall revile you, and persecute you, and shall say all manner of evil against you falsely, for My sake.

"Rejoice, and be exceeding glad: for great is your reward in heaven: for so persecuted they the prophets which were before you."

-Matthew 5:2.12.

The most complete account of the Sermon on the Mount is found in Matthew 5 to 7, and next to the so-called" Lord's Prayer," the best known part of the Sermon is doubtless that section known as "The Beatitudes," in which every verse but the last begins with the word "*Blessed*."

Most people who read these beatitudes, however, fail to ask the basic questions: "*To whom* was our Lord speaking? What were the *circumstances*? Why did He

preach this sermon?" Applying its precepts to all men alike, they say that this is the way we ought to live. But are they naive enough to suppose that if we all keep *reading* about it and *talking* about it will somehow catch on and we will ultimately enjoy what statesmen and politicians have so fruitlessly sought to attain: lasting peace and brotherhood?

The preachers of the Sermon on the Mount do indeed seem to be "so naive." They continue to preach about ethics, character building, self-improvement, community uplift, etc., but little or nothing about God's peerless plan of *salvation from sin* through the redemption that Christ wrought for us at Calvary. They continue to talk about the Fatherhood of God and the brotherhood of man, but little or nothing about man's fallen condition and his desperate need of a Savior. This is the religion of Christendom and it has resulted largely from a failure to obey II Tim. 2:15: "*rightly dividing the Word of truth*." But such emphasis on good works will never succeed in reforming fallen human nature, and it is a great mistake to suppose that this was the purpose of the Sermon on the Mount.

TO WHOM ADDRESSED

The *first* question we must ask in considering the Sermon on the Mount is: To whom was our Lord addressing His remarks? To all men? Most assuredly not, for not only was He sent *to none "but unto the lost sheep of the house of Israel,"* but he clearly instructed His apostles not to go to the Gentiles, or even to the Samaritans, but only to "the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (Matt. 15:24, 10:5,6). But He was not even addressing the people of Israel as such at this time, for we read that "seeing the multitudes, He went up into a mountain" and that there He addressed *"His disciples"* (Matt. 5:1). Indeed, all through this sermon our Lord distinguishes His disciples, His followers, from the world, even the religious world, about them.

Certainly He was not addressing the members of the Church of our day for, as we have already begun to see, much of what He said does not and cannot be applied to the members of the Body of Christ. The merciful today do not always obtain mercy; those who mourn are by no means always comforted; peacemakers are not generally called the children of God and certainly the *meek* do not inherit the earth today. They never have inherited it since these promises were first made.

As we study this sermon, then, let us place ourselves, in our imagination, back there among that audience of Jewish believers, for certainly all this took place considerably before the Church of today, the Body of Christ, even came into existence.

The prophecies of the Old Testament concerning Messiah had been so far fulfilled that He had actually come, and the establishment of His kingdom was "at hand." This is why John the Baptist, our Lord and His twelve apostles all went

about proclaiming the same message: *"The kingdom of heaven is at hand"*[9] (Matt. 3:1,2; 4:17; 10:7). Theirs was "the gospel of the kingdom," not "the gospel of the grace of God," and certainly not" the preaching of the cross."

Actually, this great sermon and especially its Beatitudes, is one of the strongest evidences that the Body of Christ and this entire dispensation of grace was then still a mystery, or secret, "hid in God" as the Apostle Paul so often insists (Eph. 3:1-11; Col. 1:24-2:2), for our Lord addressed His disciples, the remnant of believers in Israel, as if the prophesied time of tribulation were imminent and the establishment of His kingdom were soon to take place.

The Beatitudes, then, give us the characteristics of those who will be heirs of the kingdom one day to be established on this earth. They have rightly been called, along with the Sermon as a whole, *the charter of the kingdom.*

Against this background let us then consider each of the Beatitudes individually and see how perfectly they harmonize with "the gospel of the kingdom," which our Lord and His apostles had been preaching.

THE BEATITUDES INDIVIDUALLY CONSIDERED

"Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (Ver. 3).

The millennial kingdom will be made up, not of those who are spiritually smug and self-satisfied, but rather of those who realize their spiritual need. There is nothing that God hates like pride, and it will not be tolerated under the reign of Christ. Rather His kingdom will be built on humility and love.

But sinners today are not asked to be anything to inherit a position in Christ, but only to *trust in Him* who died for our sins.

"Blessed are they that mourn, for they shall be comforted" (Ver. 4).

This promise is particularly significant in the light of the Old Testament prophecies and Pentecost, for this mourning has a special relation to Israel's latter days. This is evident as we consider the *essence* of the ministry and message of John the Baptist, our Lord on earth and the twelve apostles. As we have seen, these all came crying to apostate Israel to "repent" in view of the fact that the kingdom of heaven was at hand.

Instead of repenting, however, Israel crucified her Messiah, but in response to our Lord's prayer on the cross for their forgiveness (Luke 23:34), God graciously gave the nation another chance as at Pentecost Peter offered them the *return* of

[9] Note carefully: Not a kingdom *in* heaven. They referred to the kingdom *of* heaven to be set up on *earth* (See Dan. 2:44; cf. Jer. 23:5; Luke 2:14; Matt. 6:10).

Christ if they would still repent (Acts 2:38; 3:19-21). But again, rather than repent they stood by their awful deed, even stoning Stephen to death and waging war against the disciples of Christ.

And now, is it possible that Israel will be saved *without repenting* of her sins and of her national responsibility for the crucifixion of Christ? The Hebrew Scriptures themselves give the answer. Consider them carefully all who enquire how Israel will finally be saved. Referring to the latter-day siege of Jerusalem and the subsequent return of Christ, Zechariah says:

"And I will pour upon the house of David, and upon the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the spirit of grace and of supplications: and THEY SHALL LOOK UPON ME WHOM THEY HA VE PIERCED, AND THEY SHALL MOURN FOR HIM AS ONE MOURNETH FOR HIS ONLY SON, AND SHALL BE IN BITTERNESS FOR HIM, AS ONE THAT IS IN BITTERNESS FOR HIS FIRSTBORN.

"IN THAT DAY SHALL THERE BE A GREAT MOURNING IN JERUSALEM. . . .

"AND THE LAND SHALL MOURN, EVERY FAMILY APART. . . , AND THEIR WIVES APART..." (Zech. 12:10-14),

What a scene! In that day Israel will finally respond to God's call to repent and turn to Christ, and friends and neighbors, even husbands and wives, will be ashamed to look at each other as they mourn over their long rejection of their Messiah.

This agrees with the words of our Lord in Matt. 24:30:

"... and then shall all the tribes of the earth [land][10] I mourn, and they shall see the Son of man coming in the clouds of heaven with power and great glory."

It agrees also with Rev. 1:1:

"Behold, He cometh with clouds, and every eye shall see Him, and they also which pierced Him, and all the kindreds[11] of the earth [land] shall wail because of Him. Amen."

There are many other Old Testament Scriptures along this line, which indicate that Israel will not be saved until she turns in repentance to her crucified and long-rejected Messiah. This will be the occasion of her "mourning." Then, and not until then, will the prophecies be fulfilled which say:

"And in that day there shall be a fountain opened to the house of David and to

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[10] The Greek *ge* is used alike for *earth* and *land*. Associated here as it is with Israel and with "tribes," we believe the term "land" to be correct.
[11] Same word as "tribes" in Matt. 24:30.

the inhabitants of Jerusalem for sin and uncleanness" (Zech. 13:1).

"Therefore the redeemed of the Lord shall return, and come with singing unto Zion; and everlasting joy shall be upon their head: they shall obtain gladness and joy; and sorrow and mourning shall flee away.

"I, even I, am He that comforteth you.. ." (Isa. 51:11,12).

"Comfort ye, comfort ye My people, saith your God.

"Speak ye comfortingly to Jerusalem, and cry unto her, that her warfare is accomplished, that her iniquity is pardoned; for she hath received of the Lord's hand double for all her sins" (Isa. 40:1,2).

The historical, or dispensational, order of the events discussed above is clearly brought out in one brief passage in Isa. 61:1-3:

"... the Lord hath anointed Me[12] to preach good tidings unto the meek. . .

"To proclaim [1] the acceptable year of the Lord. . . [2] the day of vengeance of our God; [3] to comfort all that mourn.

"To appoint unto them that mourn in Zion, to give unto them, beauty for ashes, the oil of joy for mourning, the garment of praise for the spirit of heaviness; that they might be called trees of righteousness, the planting of the Lord, that He might be glorified."

From these and other Old Testament prophecies we learn the significance of our Lord's promise in the Beatitudes, "Blessed are they that mourn, for they shall be comforted."

But is this how men are saved today? By no means, for when God interrupted the prophetic program to bring in the dispensation of grace, He sent Paul to proclaim to all men that God had *enthroned grace* (Rom. 5:20,21), committing to him "the *gospel*," the *good news*, "of the *grace of God*" (Acts 20:24). Unlike Peter at Pentecost, Paul does not charge men with the crucifixion of Christ. He does not say" *You* did it." Rather he says,

"[*God*] hath made Him to be sin for us . . . that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him" (II Cor. 5:21).

In Rom. 5:10 he makes the amazing statement that "we [once enemies] were *reconciled* to God by *the death of HIS Son*."

Whereas, according to the prophetic program, the cross made the enmity

[12] I.e., Christ (Luke 4:18).

between God and man (Psa. 2:1-5; 110:1), Paul declares that according to God's secret, eternal purpose the enmity was slain by the cross, i.e., He counted that death the payment for our sins, so that He could "preach peace" to us Gentiles "who were afar off, and to them [Israel] that were nigh" (Eph. 2:16,17).

Thus in Paul's message our Lord is no longer seen as a victim - even a voluntary victim - at Calvary, but as *the Great Victor* over Satan, sin, death and the Law. It is He who made an "open show" of Satan and all his hosts at Calvary, "triumphing over them in it [i.e., in the cross]" (Col. 2:15), at the same time taking the Law "out of the way" for tIs, and "nailing it to His cross" (Ver. 14). It is He who, at the cross, paid the just penalty for our sins and delivered us from the fear of death (Heb. 2:14). Where, in the Sermon on the Mount, do we find any of this?

But we must hurry on.

"Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth" (Ver. 5).

We have already seen from Ver. 3 our Lord's promise that the "poor in spirit" should inherit the kingdom. Here He adds that they shall "inherit the earth," and it is more than possible that He chose these words directly from Psa. 37:11, where we read:

"But the meek shall inherit the earth, and shall delight themselves in the abundance of peace."

Obviously our Lord spoke these words with the kingdom in view, for the meek surely do not inherit the earth today. No such change has taken place since He preached this Sermon. When this promise was made the Roman Empire held sway with brutal force and during the nineteen centuries which have followed it has been tyrants like Julius Caesar, Napoleon Bonaparte, Adolf Hitler, Benito Mussolini and Josef Stalin who have acquired large portions of this earth (temporarily of course) by sword and conquest. But when our Lord returns to reign, the meek will indeed *inherit the earth*. How refreshing to contemplate!

But while it is not ours to inherit the earth, we are given a position in the highest heavens in and with Christ, for by grace God has *"made us {to] sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus"* (Eph. 2:6), and has there "blessed us with all spiritual blessings . . . in Christ" (Eph. 1:3). And some day, in changed or resurrected bodies we shall be "caught up" to meet and be with Him forever, not only positionally, but actually, corporeally (I Thes. 4:16-18; I Cor. 15:51,52). *"What a day of rejoicing that will be!"*

"Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness, for they shall be filled" (Ver. 6).

It must not be supposed that the Lord Jesus speaks here of *imputed*

righteousness, for the great theme of Paul's Epistle to the Romans was clearly not the theme of our Lord's message to these Jewish disciples.

Again we must put ourselves into the position of our Lord's hearers if we would have a clear understanding of His message to them. Under the brutal heel of Rome, the people of Israel had to bear much injustice and unrighteousness. Indeed they suffered much injustice from their own religious leaders too (Matt. 23:1-4), and daily observed their unrighteous dealings (Vers. 5-7). Naturally, therefore, there were many whose hearts hungered and thirsted after righteousness, and in this beatitude we have our Lord's promise that in His kingdom such hunger and thirst will be fully satisfied.

Again the Old Testament Scriptures confirm this interpretation of the passage,[13] for Jer. 23:5 declares that our Lord, in His coming reign, will "execute judgment and justice in the earth," and Isa. 11:4 assures us that He will "reprove with equity for the meek of the earth." He will judge in their behalf. Again, Isa. 32:1 declares that under His reign "princes shall rule in judgment," and Isa. 26:9 that "the inhabitants of the world will learn righteousness." Indeed, Old Testament prophecy is replete with promises and descriptions of the righteousness that will prevail on earth at that time. And thus *those who "hunger and thirst after righteousness shall be filled. "*

But in Paul's epistles our *glorified* Lord goes straight to the heart of the matter, explaining that man's case is hopeless apart from redeeming grace. "The Scripture," he says, "hath concluded *all* under sin" (Gal. 3:22), since "there is none righteous, no, not one" (Rom. 3:10). Indeed, he explains that the Law was given for the express purpose of demonstrating man's *un*righteousness, for by it "all the world" has been brought in *"guilty before God"* (Rom. 3:19). Hence man's urgent need of justification before God before he even begins to be concerned about "social justice."

Thank God, by His grace, and on the basis of the blood shed at Calvary, this need has been gloriously supplied, for in ushering in the present "dispensation of the grace of God," the Apostle exclaims:

"BUT NOW the righteousness of God without the law is manifested. . . Even the righteousness of God, which is by [the] faith of[14] Jesus Christ Being justified freely by His grace, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.... To declare, I say, at this time, His [Christ's] righteousness, THAT HE [GOD] MIGHT BE JUST AND THE JUSTIFIER OF HIM THAT BELIEVETH IN JESUS" (Rom. 3:21-26).

Blessed indeed are those who hunger and thirst after *this* righteousness!

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[13] An intimate knowledge of the Old Testament Scriptures greatly facilitates the understanding of the Beatitudes and the whole Sermon on the Mount. Indeed, this is *the key* to their understanding.

[14] Note: "the faith *of*," not "faith *in*," for he speaks subjectively of the fact that Christ, having paid our debt at Calvary, will *keep faith* with all who trust in Him for salvation.

Hallelujah! The redemption wrought by Christ at Calvary has made it a righteous thing for God to justify believing sinners! Thus Paul, in writing to the Philippian believers, expresses what J. Sidlow Baxter has called, the longing of "his Christ-intoxicated heart":

"That I may be . . . found *in Him*, not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through the faith of[15] Christ, the righteousness which is of God by faith" (Phil. 3:9).

"Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy" (Ver. 7).

While it is true that in the kingdom program even a "cup of cold water," given "only in the name of a disciple," shall "in no wise lose [its] reward," we feel that the above passage has to do with *reciprocal* mercy shown *between men*. Spontaneous and reciprocal love will, in that day, prevail.

It is also true that the *principle* that those who show mercy generally, or often, obtain mercy in return, is interdispensational in character. Yet this principle has not operated consistently in any dispensation thus far, not even in the present dispensation of the grace of God. Ask the multitudes of kindly people who lived in Germany under Hitler only a few decades ago, or those others in East Berlin who, at this moment, are held captive like wild animals in a cage, many of them separated from their families and loved ones.

Ah, but our Lord's reign will usher in a bright new day, when "the merciful shall obtain mercy," nor is it altogether His doing that these "times of refreshing" have not yet been realized on earth (See Luke 19:41,42; Matt. 23:37-39).

God has provided something better, though, for those who trust in Christ during "this present evil age," for we may rejoice in the glorious" gospel of the grace of God. " We were once *"the children of disobedience,"* and therefore *"by nature the children of wrath,"*

"But God, who is rich in mercy, for His great love wherewith He loved us,

"Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ (by grace ye are saved),

"And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus:

"That in the ages to come He might show the exceeding riches of His grace in His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:4-7).

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[15] Subjective again. See above, and the author's brochure, *The Faith of Christ.*

Thus while, for the time being, this world knows little or nothing of the blessings that will prevail on earth during the millennium, God's people today are *"blessed. . . with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ"* (Eph. 1:3).

"Blessed are the pure in heart for they shall see God" (Ver. 8)

It is in Isaiah's famous prophecy of the) coming of the virgin-born Son of God, that His name is called "*Emmanuel* - which being interpreted is, *God with us"* (Matt. 1:23; cf. Isa. 7:14). The believing Jew, therefore, saw God in Christ when He came to earth (John 1:1,14; Matt. 16:16), though indeed His deity was veiled under His humiliation.

Our Lord knew, however, even as He preached the Sermon on the Mount, that He would be rejected by Israel and banished as an Exile from His own nation and from the world He had created (John 1:10,11). It was thus *to His disciples* that He proclaimed the promise that "the pure in heart" should "see God," and this will indeed be fulfilled when He returns in glory to reign.

This beatitude, like all the others, is based upon Old Testament Scripture. Indeed it is one of the great Millennial Psalms, Psalm 24,that our Lord seems to be referring to here. The 3rd and 4th verses of this Psalm read:

"Who shall ascend into the hill of the Lord? or who shall stand in His holy place?"

"He that hath clean hands, and a pure heart...."

While our Lord is not now on earth as "the King of glory" (Psa. 24:7-10), and we cannot see Him with our physical eyes, we enjoy a higher *position* at God's right hand in Christ (Eph. 2:6; Col. 3:1-3) and meanwhile rejoice as Peter did when he said:

"Whom having not seen, ye love; in whom, though now ye see Him not, yet believing, ye rejoice with joy unspeakable and full of glory" (I Pet. 1:8).

"Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called the children of God" (Ver. 9).

Again, while the words "Blessed are the peacemakers" apply to God's people in every dispensation, the promise which follows here certainly does not. In this present dispensation peacemakers are by no means always, or even generally, "called the children of God."

Often they are called troublemakers.

But the whole passage does apply specifically to the kingdom which our Lord proclaimed "at hand."

The Messianic kingdom will be characterized, perhaps chiefly, by the peace that will then prevail. When our Lord returns to reign,

"He shall judge among the nations, and shall rebuke many people; and they shall beat their swords into plowshares, and their spears into pruninghooks. Nation shall not lift up sword against nation, neither shall they learn war any more" (Isa. 2:4).

In Isa. 9:6 Messiah is called "the Prince of Peace," and Ver. 7 adds:

"Of the *increase* of His government and peace there shall be no end...."

But before international peace can be achieved there must be peace among God's people, and this is the very essence of the Sermon on the Mount: the peace that flows from sincere love, and will one day flow from Jerusalem to the ends of the earth. This peace we, as members of the Church today, should daily seek to foster (Rom. 14:19), not in view of the kingdom to be established, but as fellow-members of the "one body" (Eph. 4:3-6).

But while there cannot be international peace until our Lord returns to judge and rebuke the nations (Isa. 2:4), nor even peace prevailing among God's people Israel, until the Spirit takes control (Ezek. 36:27), the very message we are commissioned to proclaim today is one of *"grace and peace,"* not peace among men, but personal *peace with God,* made possible by grace. Everyone of Paul's signed epistles opens with the salutation:

"Grace be to you and peace, from God the Father, and from our Lord Jesus Christ."

The peace which men will enjoy under Messiah's reign will be largely destroyed again immediately at its close,[16] as we read in Rev. 20:7-9, but the peace which Paul's epistles proclaim will never be impaired or disrupted, for it is the gift of God's grace through the finished work of Christ,

"Who was delivered for our offences, and was raised again for our justification.

"Therefore being justified by faith we have PEACE WITH GOD, through our Lord Jesus Christ" (Rom. 4:25-5:1).

And thus having come to enjoy "peace *with* God" by faith, what but our own sin and unbelief can hinder us from enjoying "the peace *of* God" (Phil. 4:6,7).

May God help us to fulfil our commission to proclaim reconciliation and peace to a world at enmity with God, that many may come to know "peace with God" and

[16] Though the kingdom itself and His people will not be destroyed (Isa. 9:7).

"the peace of God" (Here the reader should carefully study II Cor. 5:14-21 and Eph. 2:11-18.).

"Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

"Blessed are ye when men shall revile you, and persecute you, and shall say all manner of evil against I you falsely, for My sake.

"Rejoice, and be exceeding glad, for great is your reward in heaven: for so persecuted they the prophets which were before you" (Vers. 10-12).

It should be observed that Verso 10-12 are actually one beatitude, having to do with the persecution through which our Lord's disciples were to pass. Thus the Beatitudes open and close with the promise to our Lord's faithful followers that "theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (Vers. 3,10,11).

We, the members of the Body of Christ, the Church of the present dispensation, have suffered at least some of the expressions of hostility mentioned in the above passage, and for this we too shall receive generous rewards. But it is never said of us that ours is the kingdom of heaven. Ours is rather a present *position* in the heavenlies in Christ, and the *prospect* of living and reigning with Him there.

But were not our Lord's disciples looking forward to reigning with Him *in Heaven?* No, for the kingdom of heaven is to be set up *on earth*, as the following Scriptures clearly demonstrate:

". . . a King shall reign and prosper, and shall execute judgment and justice in the earth" (Jer. 23:5).

"Glory to God in the highest and on earth peace, good will toward men" (Luke 2:14).

"Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth" (Matt. 5:5).

"Thy kingdom *come*. Thy will be done *in earth* as it is in heaven" (Matt. 6:10).

These and a host of other passages regarding the coming kingdom should help us to understand God's program for Israel, for they emphasize the fact that "the kingdom of heaven" is to be set up on earth. Bereans will soon take note that God's promises to Israel are *all earthly* in sphere, while our position, our blessings and our prospect are *all heavenly*.

But does not our Lord promise His hearers, in this last beatitude: "great is your reward *in heaven*"? This is true, but we must not read into this that He referred to

a reward which they were to receive when they reached heaven.[17] In I Pet. 1:4 Peter, the apostle of the circumcision, declares to his readers that their inheritance is "*reserved* in heaven" for them. Likewise in Rev. 22:12, a passage having to do directly with the return of Christ to earth to reign, we read His words:

"And, behold, I come quickly, and *My reward is with Me*, to give to every man according as his work shall be."

So the rewards to which our Lord's disciples looked forward were "reserved" for them "in heaven," from whence He will return to "give to every man according as his work shall be."

That the apostles did rejoice in their sufferings for Christ is verified by the record of the Acts. In the closing verses of Acts 5 we read how the religious leaders lowered themselves to the level of common bullies as, finding no just reason to condemn the apostles, they had them beaten and further commanded them not to speak in the name of Jesus before letting them go.

But the lashes did not bring only suffering and pain, for were not the apostles bearing them for the blessed Messiah, with whom they hoped soon to be reigning? Thus the record continues:

"And they departed from the presence of the council, rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer shame for His name.

"And daily in the temple, and in every house, they ceased not to teach and preach Jesus Christ" (Acts 5:41,42).

Little wonder the account continues:

" And in those days. . . the number of the disciples was multiplied... And the Word of God increased and the number of the disciples multiplied in Jerusalem greatly" (Acts 6:1-7).

But when we come to the epistles of Paul, Christian suffering takes on a whole new dimension. It is called *"the fellowship of His sufferings."* Indeed, in Phil 3:10 Paul expresses his desire:

"That I may know Him and the power of His resurrection, and the *fellowship of His sufferings*, being made comformable unto His death."

Perhaps this phrase, *"the fellowship of His sufferings,"* can be best explained by comparing it with another passage, in which the Apostle declares:

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[17] We do not deal here with the situation of those who later came into an enlarged hope, but to what our Lord promised His disciples then.

"[I] now rejoice in my sufferings for you, and fill up that which is behind of the afflictions of Christ in my flesh for His Body's sake, which is the Church" (Col. 1:24).

What does the Apostle mean here by "filling up that which is behind[18] of the afflictions of Christ"? Are not our Lord's sufferings past? Did He not pay the *full* price for our sins at Calvary?

The answer is found in "the mystery" which was the very theme of Paul's message. According to the prophetic Scriptures our Lord was to ascend to take His place at the Father's right hand until His *enemies* should be made His footstool (Psa. 110:1). Israel's rejection of Christ at Pentecost was to be followed by God's judgment in the Great Tribulation, and there was nothing in prophecy to indicate that the latter would not quickly follow the former (Joel 2:28-32; cf. Acts 2:16-21).

In unfathomable mercy and love, however, God has extended the "until" of Psa. 110:1, bringing in the present dispensation of grace. The rejected Lord, instead of returning "to judge and make war," now sends His enemies a message of "grace and peace," voluntarily remaining a Royal Exile while the ungodly masses continue to reject Him, blaspheme His name and persecute His followers.

But who actually bears the present enmity of men against Christ? The answer is: *we do* - or *should*. When our Lord raised up Paul this was already made plain. Paul, then Saul, had led Israel and the world in rebellion against God and His Christ and had caused many (both men and women, Acts 9:2; 22:4) to suffer and die for the name of Christ. And now, instead of crushing the rebellion - and Saul - the Lord was to permit it to continue, saving Saul and sending him forth with an offer of reconciliation, by grace, through faith alone, on the basis that God had made Christ to be sin for us so that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him. This would entail much suffering.

Thus our Lord had said to Ananias, regarding Paul:

"I will show him how great things he must suffer for My name's sake" (Acts 9:16).

And thus Paul suffered persecution and bonds and death as an Ambassador of the rejected Christ. But this suffering was sweet to him for it was not merely for Christ he suffered; it was more than this, for he now bore the sufferings *the Lord Himself* would have borne were He now on earth. II Cor. 5:20 clearly explains that Paul took our Lord's place in praying men to be reconciled; *"We pray you in Christ's stead."*

As Christ had gone to Calvary in *Paul's stead*, so Paul now stood before men in Christ's stead - and he is our example; as Christ went to Calvary *in our stead* we

[18] Or, "which still remains."

beseech men in His stead, to be reconciled to God. We are His personal representatives in His absence.

Man has declared in no uncertain terms that he is through with Christ, but Christ is not yet through with man. He loves men still and longs that they may be saved, having come to earth expressly to die for man's sins.

Thus Paul now calls his sufferings as the ambassador of Christ, "the fellowship of His sufferings" and rejoices in "filling up that which still remains of the afflictions of Christ."

And still today the Lord of love and glory remains an Exile from His own world. And still He sends ambassadors forth – *us* - to beseech men in His stead to be reconciled to God (II Cor. 5:18,19). And still those who serve Him faithfully in this capacity must be ready to suffer for it. Ah, but this is the sweetest suffering man can bear: "the *fellowship* of *His* sufferings."

Do all believers experience "the fellowship of His sufferings"? No. No more than all the disciples in Acts suffered *for* Christ.

But note: in Phil. 3:10 the Apostle Paul places "the power of His resurrection" *before* "the fellowship of His sufferings." Should not "the power of His resurrection" *follow* "the fellowship of His sufferings"?

Actually, the Apostle is saying just the opposite here. He is saying that we come into the fellowship of Christ's sufferings only as *we experience the power of His resurrection.*

In Eph. 1:19-21 we learn that God would have every believer know:

"What is the exceeding greatness of His power to us-ward who believe, according to the working of His mighty power,

"Which He wrought in Christ, when He raised Him from the dead, and set Him at His own right hand in the heavenly places.

"Far above all. . . ."

It is in the measure that we enter into this great truth and let our lives be revolutionized by it, and in that measure alone, that His power will be demonstrated in our ministry and thus - and thus alone - will we come to experience the afflictions of Christ that still remain and the sweet "fellowship of His sufferings." Satan has little inclination to trouble himself about those who do not demonstrate resurrection power.

Surely it is evident from all the above that the Sermon on the Mount directly

involves the remnant of Israel, not the Body of Christ; that it has to do with a way of life on earth, not with the way of salvation for needy sinners in "this present evil age," or the glorious prospect that awaits believers in Christ today.

As we have said, the Sermon on the Mount, and especially the Beatitudes, are the charter of the kingdom to be established on earth at Jerusalem; they do not have to do with the Body of Christ and its heavenly position and prospect. In a word: they relate to the *kingdom* of Christ, not to the *Body* of Christ.

The Sermon, and its Beatitudes, showed the hearers how to have good human relations, but they did not deal with the impossibility of man's achieving this in his present sinful condition. Like the Law, the Sermon on the Mount taught its most important lessons *historically*, for after more than 1900 years it is surely evident that man, in his present state cannot, surely does not, live up to the Sermon on the Mount.

We pity those who are using the Sermon on the Mount to preach a "social gospel" rather than proclaiming the saving gospel so clearly presented in the epistles of Paul, those who, after all these centuries do not see the futility of trying to improve human nature.

Certainly a fair consideration of the Beatitudes should reveal to them that:

The "poor in spirit" today do not inherit "the kingdom of heaven."

Those who mourn today are not always comforted.

The meek today do not "inherit the earth."

Those who "hunger and thirst after righteousness" in this scene of injustice and unrighteousness, are not "filled."

The merciful today do not necessarily, or consistently, "obtain mercy" in return. Often they receive the very opposite.

It is not "the pure in heart" today that are promised that they shall "see God," but poor sinners who will place their trust in Christ.

Nor are "the peacemakers" always, or even consistently, called "the children of God." Indeed, those who proclaim God's great message of grace and peace are often called troublemakers. In any case, we do not become the children of God by any virtue or effort of our own, but are rather the children of God in Christ, His beloved Son. (Eph. 1:6).
Finally, those who are "persecuted for righteousness' sake" today are not promised that "theirs is the kingdom of heaven."

Rather they are instructed how, by faith, f they may be lifted above the troubles and sorrows of this sin-sick world and enjoy *"all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ"* (Eph. 1:3).

Chapter V

THE SERMON ON THE MOUNT AND YOUR FINANCES

"ALL THINGS COMMON"

Those who proclaim the Sermon on the Mount today surely do not obey its precepts where finances are concerned. And these precepts are clearly defined.

"Give to him that asketh thee, and from him that would borrow of thee turn thou not away" (Matt 5:42).

". .. Take no thought[19] for your life, what ye shall eat, or what ye shall drink; nor yet for your body, what ye shall put on. Is not the life more than meat, and the body than raiment?

"Behold the fowls of the air: for they sow not, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns; yet your heavenly Father feedeth them. Are ye not much better than they?" (Matt. 6:25,26).

Here is where so many claim that our Lord *could not* have meant exactly what He said, but was rather speaking in general or comparative terms.

But this is an attempt to explain *away* the clear teachings of our Lord. Indeed, in a parallel passage in Luke He went even farther, closing His remarks on this subject by saying:

"But rather seek ye the kingdom of God, and all these things shall be added unto you.

"Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the kingdom.

"Sell that ye have, and give alms..." (Luke 12:31-33).

But what have the theologians done with this plain passage of Scripture? They have altered its meaning completely. Ver. 31 is made, in some vague way, to teach that we should seek the *things* of God. Ver. 32 is made, even more vaguely, to teach that though but a "little flock" we need not fear, for God will give us the victory. And as to Ver. 33, seldom indeed do they even mention that. What a travesty on the truth!

There need be no misunderstanding our Lord's words, nor is the popular misrepresentation of them to be justified in any way, for their meaning is clear: 1.

[19] Or, "be not concerned."

Seek the kingdom. 2. It is your Father's good pleasure *to give you the kingdom.* 3. *Sell that ye have, and give alms.* What authority do popular teachers have to *alter* Ver. 31 and 32 and to utterly ignore Ver. 33?

How, then, were the disciples to "seek first the kingdom" and to be assured that thus "all these things" would be "added" to them? Simply by heeding His words and obeying the principles and commands for the establishment of the kingdom.

And what did our Lord mean when He said that it was His Father's good pleasure to *give* them the kingdom? Surely this should not be difficult to determine in the light of His words in Matt. 21:43, where He says to the rulers who rejected Him:

"Therefore say I unto you, The Kingdom of God shall be *taken from* you, and *given to* a nation bringing forth the fruits thereof."

Mark well, He did not say that *the gospel* would be sent to *the Gentiles,* as this passage is generally interpreted to mean, but that *the kingdom* would be given to *"a nation bringing forth the fruits thereof,"* i.e., *a nation* bringing forth the fruits of *the kingdom* (as explained in the Sermon on the Mount).

The kingdom, the authority, then, was to be *"taken from"* the then rulers of Israel and *"given to"* the "little flock" of His followers.

Thus it was indeed "the Father's good pleasure" to "'give" the kingdom to our Lord's disciples. In fact He had already appointed twelve men to be the chief rulers with Him in its government:

"And Jesus said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed Me, in the regeneration, when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of His glory, *ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel"* (Matt. 19:28),

In the light of these facts, read just as they are stated, how naturally Luke 12:33 follows Verses 31 and 32! 1. *Seek* the kingdom. 2. It is your Father's good pleasure to *give* you the kingdom. 3. *Sell that ye have, and give alms.*

And as we have seen, when these disciples were "baptized" and "filled" with the Holy Spirit they carried out these last instructions, selling their possessions and goods and parting them to all men as every man had need (Acts 2:45). *"Neither said any of them that aught of the things which he possessed was his own; but they had all things common"* (Acts 4:32).

What a way to live! And this is how they *did* live with the return of Christ and the establishment of His kingdom in view. Indeed, this is how all Israel would have lived, had they responded in repentance and faith to Peter's offer of the return of Christ and *"the times of refreshing"* (Acts 3:19,20).

"EVERY MAN ACCORDING TO HIS ABILITY"

But when Israel resisted the Holy Spirit and rejected Messiah and His kingdom even after the mighty demonstrations of Pentecost, God began to interrupt the prophetic program. Soon a worldwide dearth was predicted which would, of course, affect the Judaean economy more than any other. Therefore the *Gentile* church at Antioch "determined to send relief" to the Judaean brethren, not out of one common treasury, but *"every man according to his ability"* (Acts 11:29).

Indeed, the financial condition of the Judaean saints became so critical that before the record of Acts is ended we find Paul raising funds among the *Gentile* churches of Achaia, Macedonia, Galatia and other areas, for *"the poor saints. . . at Jerusalem"* (I Cor. 16:1; Rom. 15:26), so drastically had the picture changed.

And today we find ourselves in a situation where it would be dangerous and wrong to follow our Lord's instructions to His disciples to "consider the ravens" and refrain from laying up store for the future. Rather we must now again heed the Scripture which says:

"Go to the ant, thou sluggard; consider her ways and be wise. . . . [She] provideth her meat in the summer, and gathereth her food in the harvest" (Prov. 6:6-8).

PAUL AND OUR FINANCES

That this last should be our mode of life during "this present evil age," is clear from the Spirit-inspired words of the Apostle Paul, who wrote to the Thessalonians:

"For even when we were with you, this we commanded you, that *if any would not work, neither should he eat"* (II Thes. 3:10).

And it was on the authority of the glorified Lord that the Apostle wrote to Timothy:

"But if any provide not for his own, and specially for those of his own house, he hath *denied the faith,* and is *worse than an infidel [unbeliever]"* (I Tim. 5:8).

Under the kingdom program it was a *sin* to be rich, for all were expected to sell their belongings and deposit the proceeds into a common treasury kept for "every man as he had need." When Ananias and Sapphira sought to join this program by deceitful means, secretly holding back part of the price from a sale, they were stricken dead (Acts 5:1-11). This was the carrying out of the warning with which the Sermon on the Mount closes.

Indeed, when our Lord on earth told the rich young ruler: *"Sell that thou hast, and give to the poor"* the ruler *"went away sorrowful for he had great possessions"*

(Matt. 19:21,22). And when our Lord declared further that the rich would "hardly enter into the kingdom of heaven," He did not mean that such would *barely* enter the kingdom but that it would be *difficult* for them to do so since it would mean *the giving up of their earthly possessions.*

But under "the dispensation of the grace of God" it is not a sin to be rich if such riches are fairly and honestly gained, or perhaps inherited, and are used for the glory of God. The ascended Lord, through Paul, has a special word for members of the Body of Christ who *are* rich, and also for those who *have their hearts set on riches.*

"They that *will be* rich," he says, *"fall into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition"* (I Tim. 6:9). And with regard to those who *are* rich he instructs Timothy:

"Charge them that are rich in this world, that they *be not high-minded, nor trust in uncertain riches,* but in the living God, who giveth us richly all things to enjoy:

"That they *do* good, that they be *rich in good works,* ready to distribute, willing to communicate;[20]

"Laying up in store for themselves a good foundation against the time to come, that they may lay hold on eternal life" (I Tim. 6:17-19).

Here we quote a passage from the author's commentary on I Timothy:[21]

Thus, earnestly as Paul warned both pastor and people not to "will to be rich," earnestly as he counselled them against the dangers of "the love of money," there was still the question of "them that *are* rich," for some doubtless had been *born* with large family fortunes. He did not exhort these to sell their holdings and distribute them for the common good. Rather he instructed Timothy to urge them, actually to *"charge"* them, as to their *attitude* under their particular circumstances. And how sensible and appropriate are his instructions:

1. That they *"be not highminded."* The temptation toward this attitude among the rich is very great, but it is not compatible with *"godliness."* Indeed, there is good reason for the rich to resist highmindedness, as the next phrase indicates:

2. That they *"trust not in uncertain riches."* How many rich people have learned by sad experience the truth of Prov. 23:5: *"for riches certainly make themselves wings; they fly away as an eagle toward heaven."* Indeed, many rich and self-indulgent believers have been disciplined by God, for their good, as they have been stripped practically naked.

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[20] The sense is that of a generous contributor.
[21] With a few slight changes.

3. That they "trust in . . . *the living God, who giveth us richly all things to enjoy."* The term "living God," here, shows that riches can become an idol, a dead god, which, in times of deepest trouble, can neither hear nor help. How much better, then, to bow in adoration before "the *living* God" and acknowledge *Him* as the One who has *"given us richly all things to enjoy,"* realizing that we are merely His stewards, His trustees. If this is sincerely done the rest will follow naturally.

4. *"That they do good, that they be rich in good works, ready to distribute, willing to communicate"* (Ver. 18). Note: "that they *do* good," not merely *"be* good." A wealthy believer may be godly in his conduct, yet be a veritable miser, clinging tightly for himself to *that which God has entrusted* to him. Hence Paul's *"Charge them that are rich,"* to be generous contributors, gladly inclined to share with others. This is the sense of the last part of Ver. 18 and, of course, this joyful inclination to share with others would apply most importantly to sharing with others the riches of God's grace, sharing in the cost of making the blessed message known far and wide.

Thank God for the men and women of means who have used their wealth for *His* glory, investing generously in the cause of Christ. Such investments on the part of God's children comprise a sort of "spiritual nest egg" for "the time to come" (Ver. 19), for God will not forget their faithfulness to His cause when the time of rewards has arrived. And, indeed, this is an important way in which the rich may *"lay hold on eternal life"* (Ver. 19), getting out of the Christian life what it was meant to yield to them.

It has been rightly said: "You can't take it with you, but you can send it on ahead." This is exactly what I Tim. 6: 19 teaches.

How all this condemns the preaching of the social gospel, and certainly the propagation of Communism. Those who preach these things and base them on the Sermon on the Mount are living in *the wrong dispensation.*

Chapter VI

A MODEL PRAYER

Along with the Beatitudes, the other best known passage in our Lord's Sermon on the Mount is the so-called "Lord's Prayer." We use the term "so-called" advisedly, for actually this is not the *Lord's* prayer. He did not interrupt His sermon *to* engage in prayer, but rather *instructed* His disciples how *they* should pray. Nor is this the only occasion on which He did so.

The term, "The Lord's Prayer" would more accurately describe His prayer *to* His Father recorded in John 17:1-26, where He "lifted up His eyes to heaven" and *prayed to His Father* in those dark hours before His trial and crucifixion. Or, such phraseology, in the plural, might designate the three prayers in the Garden of Gethsemane, when He "fell on His face" and besought His Father that "if it be possible this hour might pass from Him," and then prayed a second time and a third, even "more earnestly" (Mark 14:35-41; Luke 22:44).

Any of the above might properly be called the *Lord's* prayer, but here in Matt. 6:9-13 He rather provides a *model* for His disciples, to teach them *how* to pray. And what a model!

AFTER THIS MANNER
Matthew 6:9-13

" After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be Thy name.

"Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.

"Give us this day our daily bread.

"And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors.

"And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: For Thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, forever. Amen."

If ever there was a *perfect* prayer, this is it. It could be nothing less than perfect, for our Lord Himself gave it to His disciples as a model prayer.

It is interesting to notice the circumstances surrounding one occasion on which this prayer was uttered:

"LORD, TEACH US TO PRAY"

" And it came to pass, that *as He was praying* in a certain place, when He

ceased, one of His disciples said unto Him, *Lord, teach us to pray,* as John also taught his disciples." (Luke 11:1)

Picture the scene!

The Lord is alone, praying as only He can pray.

He is lost in fellowship with His Father, praying, no doubt, aloud, when His disciples come upon Him.

They cannot interrupt the sacred scene. They stand there in reverent silence.

Hear Him pray! Such intimacy! Such simplicity! Such faith! What bold requests He makes! Yet, how humbly He subjects all to the Father's will!

This is the second person of the Trinity! God the Son! See Him now, earnestly *praying!* How He has humbled Himself!

Little wonder they stand in silent awe until He has ceased! And little wonder that when He *has* ceased, one of them cries, *"Lord, teach us to pray."*

"If only I could pray like that!" he had said to himself as he heard his Master pray. "If only I could get so close to God!"

It was the cry of his heart: *"Lord, teach us to pray."*

Of course the request was granted!

Other wonderful prayers uttered by our Lord are recorded for us, but this one is unique in that He gave it them as a pattern.

A thorough exposition of the prayer is, of course, not possible here, but let us at least examine it briefly.

THE PRAYER PERFECT

What loving intimacy it teaches!

"Our Father."

Yet what holy reverence!

"Our Father *which art in heaven, Hallowed be Thy name."*

Further, *God* is first and last in the prayer.

"Hallowed be *Thy name; Thy kingdom* come, *Thy will* be done. . ."

"For Thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory. . ."

But man's needs hold the central place!

"Give *us* this day our daily bread. And forgive *us* our debts as we forgive our debtors. And lead *us* not into temptation, but deliver *us* from evil."

Here earnest supplication and implicit faith are blended.

"Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth as it is in heaven ... For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, forever. Amen."

Here is simplicity to the point of brevity.

It has sometimes been asked in public meetings: "How many of you spend an hour or even half an hour in prayer each day?" But the Bible never deals thus with prayer.

We are told to "pray without ceasing" (never to stop praying). We are told to be "instant" in prayer, to pray "fervently," to pray "in everything," to pray "with thanksgiving," but we are never told to pray *long.*

When occasion arises, by all means let us stay upon our knees. Our Lord, at least on one occasion, "continued all night in prayer to God." But let us never try to keep praying just to please God. He does not ask for this and He does not wish it.

The only references our Lord made concerning long prayers were against the religious leaders of the day who "devour widows' houses and *for a pretence make long prayers."* (Mark 12:40). The Lord sternly rebuked them for their hypocrisy and warned the multitudes against them.

Here indeed, is the prayer perfect. Here is intimacy blended with reverence. Here the glory of God is recognized but man's need is not forgotten. Here is earnest supplication with implicit trust, and simplicity even to the point of brevity.

The vast majority of professing Christians, Protestant as well as Catholic, repeat this prayer again and again, often in unison.

We are exceptions to this rule, however, and it is our purpose now to point out just why.

WHY NOT REPEAT IT?

It is really a pity that this question needs to be discussed at all.

In His Sermon on the Mount our Lord prefaced this very prayer with the words:

"But when ye pray, *use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do: for they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking. Be not ye therefore like unto them:* for your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask Him." (Matt. 6:7,8).

And can it be that *this* is the very prayer which Christendom has chosen to repeat more than any other! Can it be that some will even repeat so many "Our Father's" at a time, when this is the very practice He warned against!

How contrary is human nature!

Our Lord first uttered this prayer to His disciples, but have you ever read of their repeating it? If He meant it to be repeated, should we not have at least *one* example in Scripture of their having done so?

The fact is that He distinctly warned them *against* making "vain repetitions," and said *"After this manner* therefore pray ye. " Our Lord's teaching here is in direct contradiction to the heathen repetitions of religious people who still today seem to think that they will be heard for their much speaking, as though repeating this prayer one hundred times is more efficacious than repeating it once, twice or fifty times.

There is absolutely no precedent in Scripture for repeating prepared prayers, and certainly no instructions to do so. This custom comes straight from paganism. We find many prayers recorded for us in the Bible, but not once do we find the people of God reading or reciting them. Always we find them praying spontaneously, from the heart.

May we, then, take heed to our Lord's instructions:

"But when ye pray, use not *vain repetitions,* as the heathen [the pagans) do; for *they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking.*

Be not ye therefore like unto them. . ." (Vers. 7,8).

Should it be asked why the Lord called repetitions vain, the answer is simply that no prayer fits every occasion.

Let us illustrate:

I have just had the joy, let us say, of leading a precious soul to Christ. He was a godless, wicked creature until lately, but now, suddenly, a great transformation

has taken place in his life. He is overwhelmed with the joy of sins forgiven.

Nevertheless a few things still trouble him.

As he stands there, touched by the love of Christ, he says, "I don't look like a Christian. Look at my clothes. And I ought to get a job and work like other people do. Then, too, I've been a wicked blasphemer. Swearing seems to be part of my nature. I don't know how I'll ever stop it."

I suggest that we pray about it, but he says he has never prayed in his life and doesn't know how. So I teach him. I tell him how simple prayer is - that he should just say, "Lord, I need a decent suit of clothes and a job, and oh, I pray Thee to help me to stop swearing. I ask it in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ."

We arise from prayer, and feeling for the man, I myself get him a suit of clothes and a job and he goes on his way rejoicing.

Now, let us suppose that I return ten years later to find that he is happily married, has three children and has been living a consistent Christian life.

Calling at his home, however, I find that one of his children is dangerously ill. We get on our knees to pray for the child, and he begins: "Lord, I need a decent suit of clothes and a job, and oh, wilt Thou not help me to stop swearing"!

Ridiculous! you say. No man would be so foolish. He's been a Christian now for ten years!

Yes, ridiculous, indeed! Yet in the same way the "Lord's prayer" is repeated over and over again. The very prayer which was prefaced by a caution *not* to make vain repetitions has become part of the ritual of Christendom! It is repeated in trouble and sorrow, sickness and death, storm and war, with almost no regard to its contents.

Imagine praying "Give us this day our daily bread," at a funeral service! Or imagine praying "Thy kingdom come," at a sickbed! Yet this is solemnly done again and again throughout Christendom. Often whole audiences repeat it in unison, and that in the very face of our Lord's words, "Make *not* vain repetitions." What a vast difference between praying and saying prayers!

Before showing how perfectly the" Lord's prayer" fit into their circumstances then, and how *im*perfectly it fits ours now, let us briefly consider one more argument against repeating this prayer.

At the close of His earthly ministry our Lord gave these same disciples a further revelation about prayer when He said,

"Hitherto have ye asked nothing in My name: ask, and ye shall receive, that your joy may be full.

These things have I spoken unto you in proverbs but the time cometh, when I shall no more speak unto you in proverbs, but I shall show you plainly of the Father.

"At that day ye shall ask in My name: . . ." (John 16:24-26),

After the Lord's ascension into heaven these same disciples were to make their requests to the Father *in His name.* This in itself would have excluded their repeating the so-called "Lord's prayer."

THE LORD'S PRAYER AND THE LORD'S DISCIPLES

It is fascinating to study the "Lord's prayer" in its dispensational setting and see how perfectly appropriate it was to the circumstances in which the disciples found themselves.

"Our Father which are in heaven."

In Ex. 4:22 we read, ". . . Thus saith the Lord, *Israel is my son, even my firstborn."*

Our Lord insisted on this when He replied to a pleading Gentile woman, *"It is not meet to take the children's bread, and cast it to dogs"* (Matt. 15:26).

But in what sense were the people of Israel God's children? Had they all been born again? Certainly not. Nicodemus was an Israelite but he had not been born again (John 3:3-10).

When God said to Pharaoh, *"Let My son go"* (Ex. 4:22,23) He referred, of course, to *the nation.* It was a national matter, based on a *covenant* relationship. Thus we read in Hosea 11:1,2:

"When Israel was a child, I loved Him, and called My son out of Egypt."

It was in this covenant relationship that the Lord, in His Sermon on the Mount, spoke to His disciples about the Fatherhood of God, with the desire that each might know God as his Father in a deeper sense.

"Thy kingdom come; Thy will be done in earth as it is, in heaven."

At our Lord's birth the multitude of the heavenly host had praised God, saying, "Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, good will toward men" (Luke 2:14).

It was nothing less than the millennial kingdom the angels heralded that day and this is what the disciples were told to pray for.

Thus they were instructed to *proclaim* the kingdom:

"And as ye go, preach, saying, the kingdom of heaven is at hand." (Matt. 10:7).

They were told to *practice* the kingdom.

"Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out devils: freely ye have received, freely give, provide neither gold, nor silver, nor brass in your purses." (Matt. 10:8,9).

They were told to *pray* for the kingdom.

"Thy kingdom *come,* Thy will be done in earth as it is in heaven." (Matt. 6:10).

Indeed, our Lord later promised His twelve apostles twelve thrones in that kingdom.

"Verily I say unto you, that ye which have followed Me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of His glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel:" (Matt. 19:28).

But let us continue:

"Give us this day our daily bread."

This was most appropriate for them to pray. The promise of twelve thrones was made in answer to Peter's statement, *"Behold, we have forsaken all, and followed thee."*

This was true. They had given up even their daily employment to follow the Lord Jesus, and He had told them:

"Take no thought [do not plan] for your life, what ye shall eat; neither for the body, what ye shall put on. . . . consider the ravens: for they neither sow nor reap; which neither have storehouse nor barn; and God feedeth them: how much more are ye better than the fowls" (Luke 12:22,24).

This was all in line with the kingdom program, and it explains why the disciples were told to pray *"give us this day our daily bread,"* with the assurance that this would be provided.

Certainly a great change had taken place, when, some years later, Paul took up a collection from among the Gentile believers for "the poor saints at Jerusalem!" (Rom.15:26), but that was after Israel had rejected Christ and His kingdom.

"And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors."

Let us not neutralize this clear statement, for our Lord had no more than finished the prayer, than He said,

"For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you:

"But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses." (Matt. 6:14,15).

There is a difference, of course, between the *judicial* forgiveness, or justification, proclaimed in Romans and the parental forgiveness obviously referred to here. Nevertheless salvation by grace through faith alone had not yet been manifested. These were the standards of the kingdom to be established on earth, and the subjects of this kingdom were given no hope of receiving forgiveness if they did not forgive others.

"And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil ["the evil" one]."[22]

Here is where popular interpretations depart farthest from the truth. Many who pray this prayer actually suppose that it is necessary to implore God not to lead them into evil enticement.

But we read distinctly in James 1:13,

"Let no man say when He is tempted, I am tempted of God; for God cannot be tempted with evil, *neither tempteth He any man."*

Of Christ alone it is said that He was "led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil" (Matt. 4:1), but that was *for us.* Furthermore this temptation by the devil was a demonstration of our Lord's essential deity, for He did not respond to it. Our Lord could not be tempted with evil; He was *God.*

The fact is that the English word "temptation" had a broader meaning when our Bibles were translated, than we give it today. It meant trial or testing, and the prayer "Lead us not into temptation," evidently refers to the great tribulation, *"the hour of temptation, which shall come upon all the world, to try them that dwell upon the earth"* (Rev. 3:10).

This throws light upon the last part of the phrase, which our translators have

[22] The Greek contains the definite article.

rendered "deliver us from evil," even though the *Received Text* contains the definite article. It should read, "Deliver us from *the* evil," perhaps referring to "the evil one." Let us not forget that in Rev. 12:12, we read concerning the great tribulation, that "the devil is come down unto you, having great wrath, because he knoweth that he hath but a short time," i.e., before he is judged and Christ reigns.

THE MYSTERY

It may be asked why the disciples should be taught to pray for deliverance from terrors so far in the future. The answer is simply that this dispensation of grace was a mystery "hid in God," "kept secret since the world began," until revealed through Paul (See Rom. 16:25; Eph. 1:9; 3:1-9; Col. 1:26).

In Joel's prophecy of the "last days" (Joel 2:28-32), the signs of Pentecost are followed by the signs of the great tribulation. There is no hint of any period of grace between. Peter at Pentecost quoted this passage so. He surely expected the pouring out of God's wrath to follow the pouring out of the Spirit (See Acts 2:14-21).

But since then God has "made known unto us *the mystery (or secret) of His will,"* His wonderful purpose to give the world a period of grace, and reconcile believing Jews and Gentiles to Himself in one body by the cross (Eph. 2:16).

As the Lord Jesus, in His sermon at Nazareth, "closed the book" right in the middle of His quotation of Isaiah 61:2, (cf. Isa. 61:1-3; Lu. 4:17-21), so God has "closed the book," so to speak, right in the middle of His fulfilment of Joel 2:28-32. This gap in prophecy can only be explained by "the mystery."

This secret purpose was first revealed to and through the Apostle Paul. Hear his words in Eph. 3:1-3:

"For this cause I Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles,

"If ye have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God which is given me to you-ward:

"How that by revelation He made known unto me the mystery [secret] . . ."

This great secret is *"the secret"* in more ways than one. It not only was a *secret purpose,* but it was and is the secret *of* His purpose. It is the *key* to the understanding of the program of God.

God has made known unto us the secret of His will (Eph. 1:9), but, alas, it must still be asked of the great majority of Christians, and of their spiritual leaders: *"if ye have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God which is given me [Paul] to you-ward."*

May God hasten the day when this blessed truth shall be recovered to the Church and when the multitudes of now confused and divided believers shall once more rejoice in the unadulterated gospel of the grace of God and our oneness with Christ and each other in the heavenlies!

THE LORD'S PRAYER AND THE LORD'S PEOPLE TODAY

A comparison of the so-called "Lord's Prayer" with the Epistles of Paul will reveal how much more we have in Christ than His disciples on earth had under "the gospel of the kingdom."

The very phrase "Our Father which art *in heaven,"* suggests distance. They were to pray on earth to their Father in heaven.

We do not deny that this is so physically with us too, but we do insist that we are given a position of which they knew nothing, for we are seated in the heavenlies *at the right hand of God Himself,* and have *"access by faith into this grace wherein we stand"* (Rom. 5:2). No such position is recognized in the "Lord's prayer."

Furthermore, whereas they had a claim on God as His covenant children, we may rejoice that we are the children of God *in Christ* - a much closer relationship. The apostle Paul says, "for we are members of His body, of His flesh, and of His bones." (Eph. 5:30).

We repeat that God said of Israel "Israel is My son, even My firstborn" (Ex. 4:22). But when God's "son," Israel, failed Him and disgraced Him, God set forth the Lord Jesus Christ and said *"This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased"* (Matt. 3:17).

Now salvation is offered to all freely by His grace, and the simplest believer is "accepted in the Beloved." (Eph. 1:6).

Again, we look forward to the time when God's will shall be done in earth as it is in heaven. We look forward to our Savior's coming glory, but we also praise Him for His grace in delaying His return to judge and reign. We realize that every moment He remains an Exile is a moment of grace for this doomed world, and we would obey God's Word and take advantage of every opportunity He gives us here as His ambassadors, "redeeming [buying up] the time, because the days are evil" (Eph. 5:16).

Whereas they were waiting and working and praying for the time when God's will should be done on earth as in heaven, Paul's prayer and God's purpose for us is that we may occupy our position in the heavenlies with Christ, and appropriate

our spiritual blessings there (Eph. 1:15-2:6).

"If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God.

"Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth.

"For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God" (Col. 3:1-3).

There is still another important fact to consider here.

They looked forward to the age to come, when *God's will* was to be done "in earth." But now God reveals to us that it is His loving purpose *"that in the ages to come He might show the exceeding riches of His grace in His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus"* (Eph. 2:7). What a prospect!

As to the next phrase in Matt. 6, few of us can sincerely pray, *"give us this day our daily bread,"* for we generally have considerably more than a day's supply ahead. This request harmonized with their particular circumstances.

"And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors."

Can we pray this in the light of the present truth?

Prayer for pardon implies guilt. How can we pray for pardon, *"being justified freely, by His grace, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus"* (Rom. 3:24)?

And surely "the forgiveness of sins according to the riches of His grace," exceeds by far the extent to which we forgive others.

It has been objected by some that when the Lord told them that they would not be forgiven if they did not forgive others, He referred rather to their *fellowship* with God than to their *relationship* with Him, since they were already the children of God.

But even here there is a striking contrast between that day and this.

Our Lord distinctly told them "if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses" (Matt. 6:15).

But the same Lord, now rejected on earth, but glorified in heaven, tells us through the Apostle Paul,

"And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted *forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake HATH forgiven you"* (Eph. 4:32).

In closing, we need not fear that God will allow us to go through the coming tribulation. He will speak to this world in His wrath, but God hath not appointed *"us* to wrath" (cf. Psa. 2:5 with I Thes. 5:9). The very fact that God leaves us here as His ambassadors proves that He has not yet declared war on the world. His attitude is still one of "grace and peace." Before He does declare war, He will surely recall His ambassadors.

"For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first:

"Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord.

"Wherefore comfort one another with these words" (I. Thes. 4:16.18).

Chapter VII

CLOSING CONSIDERATIONS

Before bringing this volume to a close we must deal with a few final passages which reveal the dispensational setting of the Sermon on the Mount and show how much more the believer in Christ has in the present "dispensation of the grace of God."

THE GOLDEN RULE
(Matt. 7:12)

The golden rule is a wonderful standard to live by - far above anything ever attained by this world, yet it does not rise to the heights of grace. Rather *"this is the law and the prophets."*

We, the members of the Body of Christ are told to "be kind to one another," forgiving others - not as others have forgiven us, but *"as God, for Christ's sake, hath forgiven [us]"* (Eph. 4:32).

Further the Law provided no power to carry out the golden rule, but we are told again and again to fulfil the precepts of grace "according to the power of God that worketh in us" (Eph. 1:i8,19; 3:20; II Tim. 1:7,8).

NON-RESISTANCE
(Matt. 5:38-41)

Those who have not seen the relation of this passage to the kingdom reign of Christ have made many futile attempts to practice the precepts here laid down. When the righteous King is on the throne such conduct as here described will not only be right; it will be rational.

Grace, however, goes farther. Not only should we *bear* the hostility of our enemies without thought of revenge; we should actively seek their salvation and their good. This is more than mere non-resistance, or "turning the other cheek."

ALMS, PRAYER AND FASTING
(Matt. 6:1-6; 16-18)

It has been said - probably correctly - that the Pharisees considered alms, prayer and fasting the three greatest expressions of piety, alms having to do with one's relation to his fellowman, prayer with his fellowship with God, and fasting with self-discipline.

But our Lord explained that to take part in any of these to gain the applause of men was pure hypocrisy, and this is exactly what the Pharisees did, and this will

not be tolerated in the kingdom.

These three practices are precious experiences when done in the light of grace. How beautiful is Paul's exhortation: *"He that giveth, let him do it with simplicity"* (Rom. 12:8). This is the very antithesis of the attitude reflected in Matt. 6:1,2.

As to prayer, it is indeed a sacred experience to "enter into thy closet," and "shut the door," and "pray" to our heavenly Father. But it is the more so to those who understand that during this "dispensation of the grace of God" we already have a *position* in the heavenlies at God's right hand and *"have access by faith into this grace wherein we stand"* (Rom. 5:2). Our Great High Priest does not enter the Father's presence in our stead, as did the Old Testament high priests. Rather He *leads us into the Father's presence* (Eph. 2:18; Heb. 6:19,20; 10:19,20).

As to fasting, when our Lord was on earth the required fasts of the Law were still in force. How much more blessed is the natural fasting sanctioned, though never commanded, under grace (I Cor. 7:5). Such fasting goes naturally with earnest prayer in times of deep spiritual need, and in which the mind, unencumbered with other interests may devote itself with less distraction to the subject of its requests.

LORD, LORD
(Matt. 7:21-23)

Our Charismatic friends should consider this passage thoughtfully, for many suppose that gifts of prophecy, casting out of demons and the "many wonderful works" referred to here are signs of spirituality, when in fact the carnal Corinthians wrought all these miracles and our Lord here, in the Sermon on the Mount, indicates that He will say to many who wrought these signs (when they *were* in order): *"I never knew you; depart from Me, ye that work iniquity"* (Matt. 7:21-23).

Dispensationally, it is significant that the miraculous signs which so mightily bore witness to the royal claims of Christ, are not even mentioned in the so-called prison epistles of Paul, those written after his imprisonment in Rome. Furthermore, even in Paul's earlier epistles there is much evidence that these signs were being "done away" (I Cor. 13:8; II Cor. 12:7-10; *et al).*

ASK, SEEK, KNOCK
(Matt. 7:7.10)

This passage fits naturally with such passages as Matt. 18:19 and 21:22, both related to the Messianic kingdom. We today had better thank God that we do not receive everything we ask God for, even in faith, for the Apostle Paul, in Rom. 8:26 declares that *"we know not what we should pray for as we ought,"* and we know that he himself "besought the Lord thrice" that he might be delivered from

his "thorn in the flesh," only to have the Lord assure him: *"My grace is sufficient for thee, for My strength is made perfect in weakness"* (II Cor. 12:8,9).

But this same apostle assures us that though we may not receive all we ask for in faith, *God* is working all out for our good (Rom. 8:28) and that "[He] is able to do *exceeding abundantly above* all that we ask or think,[23] according to the power that worketh in us" (Eph. 3:20). Thus the divine instruction:

"Be careful [anxious] for nothing, but in everything, by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known unto God.

"And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep [guard, defend] your hearts and minds, through Christ Jesus" (Phil. 4:6,7).

DIVORCE AND RE-MARRIAGE
(Matt. 5:31,32)

Few people are aware of the fact that the subject of marriage, divorce and re-marriage also has a dispensational aspect. God's original instructions regarding marriage (Gen. 2:24) were amended - *by God* - as time passed and circumstances changed.

UNDER THE LAW

Under the Mosaic Law it was comparatively easy for a man to procure a divorce. In certain cases if he merely did not "delight" in his wife he could dismiss her (Deut. 21:10-14). Indeed, under the Law it was possible for any man to divorce his wife merely because she found "no favor in his eyes" because he had found some "uncleanness" (Lit., something offensive) in her (Deut. 24:1-4). In that case the husband merely had to write "a bill of divorcement" (stating the reasons why he did not wish to keep her) and then "give it into *her* hand and send her out of his house."

It must not be overlooked, however, that the *reason* for these laws on divorce is clearly given by our Lord in response to the Pharisees' question, *"Why did Moses then command to give her a writing of divorcement, and to put her away?"*

"He saith unto them, Moses *because of the hardness of your hearts* suffered you to put away your wives: but from the beginning it was not so" (Matt. 19:8).

UNDER THE KINGDOM PROGRAM

Under the program of the kingdom there was only *one* justification recognized for divorce. This was *adultery:*

[23] Lit., imagine.

"And I say unto you, Whosoever shall put away his wife, *except it be for fornication,* and shall marry another, committeth adultery" (Matt. 19:9),

Unquestionably this had a dispensational significance, for Jehovah was about to divorce His wife, Israel, for adultery, and call her *"Lo-ammi," "not* My people" (Hos. 1:2,9). In the light of much Old Testament prophecy and the record of the Book of Acts, Jehovah and Israel are now divorced and estranged. But they will be reconciled and reunited when He returns to earth as Israel's Deliverer at the close of the Great Tribulation (See Isa. 62:4,5; Zeph, 3:17; Rom. 11:26,27).

UNDER GRACE

Under the present "dispensation of the grace of God," however, there is *no Scriptural ground* for obtaining a divorce. The command is: *"Let not the wife depart from her husband"* (I Cor. 7:10), and conversely the husband from his wife (Ver. 11). Realizing the great pressures that sometimes bring on divorces, and recognizing the fact that some will depart from their mates regardless of the Scriptures involved, he continues:

"But and if she depart, *let her remain unmarried,* or be reconciled to her husband. And [i.e., and *likewise*] let not the husband put away his wife" (I Cor. 7:11).

Thus the married person who is unhappy and seeking a divorce, should ponder the consequences a thousand times, for *the person who obtains a divorce* is prohibited by Scripture from ever marrying again.

We realize that there are technicalities involved as to which party did the "departing" (i.e., who was *really* responsible for the divorce), the matter of contesting the divorce suit, the question of the unsaved mate, etc. I Cor. 7 sensibly answers these and other questions, but the basic imperative for the dispensation of grace is clear: *Nowhere* in Paul's epistles do we find *any* justification for departing from one's mate or for obtaining a divorce. Grace will forgive the erring partner and show him the love of Christ.

JUDGE NOT
(Matt. 7:1-5)

All believers should *"stand" for* what is right and *"withstand"* what is wrong in I obedience to Eph. 6:10-13. When this is faithfully done, however, there are always those who criticize, using such passages as the following one from the Sermon on the Mount:

"Judge not, that ye be not judged" (Matt. 7:1).

Yet, the Apostle Paul wrote to the Corinthian believers:

"He that is *spiritual judgeth all things"* (I Cor. 2:15).

In discussing this seeming contradiction we will confine ourselves to the Greek root *krino,*[24] used in both passages above.

If the interpretation so often placed upon our Lord's words, *"Judge not,"* were consistent with the Scriptures as a whole we would not - indeed *should not* - have had a Scofield, a Darby, a Luther - or a *Paul!* Certainly those who do thus interpret our Lord's words would have taken exception as Paul and Barnabas *"had no small dissension and disputation"* with the Judaizers who had come to Antioch seeking to bring the Gentile believers under the Law of Moses, or as, later at Jerusalem, Paul "*gave place by subjection,*" to these same Judaizers, "*no not for an hour,* that the truth of the gospel might continue with [the Gentiles]" (Acts 15:2; Gal. 2:5). Thus the interpretation of any Scriptural statement on judging must be determined, not by some "private interpretation," but in the light of the context and/or of related Scripture passages.

JUDGE NOT

Our Lord's words in Matt. 7:1 have, of course, to do with judging *persons* (obviously for what they do or fail to do), but Ver. 5 indicates further that He had reference to a certain type of critic: *"Thou hypocrite,"* or one who has a *"beam"* (a log) in his own eye, while criticizing the *"mote"* (any small, dry particle) in his brother's eye. Such a person would surely not be the "spiritual" person of I Cor. 2:15. Rather, a wrong attitude makes him critical of others.

It should be still further observed that Matt. 7:1,2 taken together constitute a *warning* against being *too ready* to judge others:

"For with what judgment ye judge, ye shall be judged; and with what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you again" (Ver. 2).

This warning, indeed, holds good in our own day, for the Apostle Paul too condemns those who *hypocritically* condemn others (Rom. 2:1) and those who are *too quick* to judge (Rom. 14:4,10,12,13; I Cor. 4:5). Let us, then, rather *be judged* than to *judge;* rather *be criticized* than to *criticize others.*

HE THAT IS SPIRITUAL JUDGETH ALL THINGS

But where God has clearly revealed his truth and will, believers *should* judge between truth and error, not only "standing" for what is right, but "withstanding" what is wrong (Eph. 6:11,13) - and this often involves "judging" and even "withstanding" the *persons* involved (See Gal. 2:11-14).

[24] Along with its derivatives, *"anakrino,"* to judge strictly, and *"diakrino,"* to judge thoroughly.

Using this same word, *krino,* the Apostle says:

"But he that is *spiritual judgeth all things,* yet he himself is judged of no man" (I Cor. 2:15).

The truly spiritual man is so far above the wisest sages of this world, yea, so far above the mass of Christians with whom he comes into contact, that *he understands them,* but *they* can never quite understand him.[25] Surely there ought to be more such believers, men of God who are truly spiritual and truly qualified to judge between what is right and what is wrong, what is Scriptural and what is not. Referring to the senseless and shameful contentions among the Corinthian believers, Paul wrote:

"I speak to your shame. Is it so, that there is not a wise man among you; no, not one that shall be able to judge between his brethren?" (I Cor. 6:5; cf. Vers. 2,3).

All this is confirmed by another statement made by our Lord Himself while on earth, for in John 7:24 we have His words:

"Judge not according to the appearance, *but judge righteous judgment."*

Surely our Lord indicated by these words that His hearers *should judge - fairly and rightly,* though "hypocrites" (as in Matt. 7:1-5) should take care not to judge at all.

Thus God calls upon His people, not merely to judge others, but *to be such as are qualified, morally and spiritually,* to judge in matters where truth and error, and right and wrong conduct, are concerned.

JUDGING OURSELVES

In Paul's well-known passage on the Lord's Supper, he warns against partaking of this sacred memorial in an unworthy manner (I Cor. 11:27), and adds:

"But *let a man examine himself,* and *so* let him eat of that bread, and drink of that cup" (Ver. 28).

Concluding his remarks on this subject, he says:

"If we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged.

"But when we are judged we are chastened of the Lord, that we should not be condemned with the world" (I Cor. 11:31,32).

Away, then, with the use of our Lord's words in Matt. 7:1 as an excuse for

[25] The author's book, *True Spirituality,* deals at length with this subject.

irresponsibility and permissiveness, and especially for the criticism of those who seek to stand true to God and His Word. Our Lord's thought in this whole passage (through Ver. 5) was that *hasty* and *hypocritical* judgment of others should be put away by those who hoped to enter into the kingdom of heaven.

PERFECT OBEDIENCE
(Matt. 5:20; 7:24-27)

Under the Law perfect obedience to God was *required* (Ex. 19:5,6; Gal. 3:10). To the lawyer who sought to tempt Christ by asking Him, *"Master, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?"* our Lord countered by asking. *"What is written in the law?"* And when the lawyer quoted to Him the gist of the Ten Commandments the Lord answered simply, *"This do, and thou shalt live"* (Luke 10:25-28).

And indeed, when our Lord proclaimed the precepts of the Sermon on the Mount He demanded obedience to the Law *in the light of his righteous interpretation of it.* Technically, under the Law, if a man did not actually commit physical adultery, the Law could not touch him, but our Lord, in His Sermon, showed that *before God* the lustful look *is* adultery committed in the heart (Matt. 5:27,28).

During the Kingdom reign of Christ, perfect obedience to God will be *spontaneous* as the Holy Spirit takes *full control* of His people. As we have seen from Ezek. 36:27, God will put His Spirit within them and *"cause"* them to walk in His statutes and they *"shall keep"* His judgments and *"do"* them. Pentecost witnessed a blessed foretaste of this as "they were all *filled with the Holy Spirit"* (Acts 2:4).[26]

In *"this present evil age,"* however, we stand between the *requirement* to keep the Law for acceptance with God, and the future day when God will *supernaturally cause* His people to keep the Law. It is clear that in *none* of the churches founded by Paul were *all* of them *filled* with the Spirit. Rather *the statement of fact* in Acts 2:4 gives way to the *exhortation* of Eph. 5:18. This latter passage testifies to the fact that the Ephesians were *not* all filled with the Spirit, for it *exhorts* them: *"Be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess, but be filled with the Spirit."*

Grace and *faith* are the characteristic only is salvation declared to be *"by grace, through faith,"* but the Spirit also operates in the believer *"by grace, through faith."* What He provides by grace we may appropriate by faith. He dwells within each believer (I Cor. 6:19) to provide needed guidance and strength to withstand temptation, and we may avail ourselves of His help in time of need.

Thus we read that even in our inability to pray as we ought, *"the Spirit ... helpeth our infirmities"* and *"maketh intercession for us"* (Rom. 8:26). In our weakness we

[26] The terms *"baptized with the Spirit"* (Acts 1:5), and *"filled with the Holy Spirit"* (Acts 2:4) indicate the Spirit's *complete control* over them.

are *"strengthened with might by His Spirit in the inner man"* (Eph. 3:16). And God even stoops to *"quicken our mortal bodies by His Spirit that dwelleth in us"* (Rom. 8:11).

"Therefore, brethren, we are debtors, not to the flesh, to live after the flesh" (Ver. 12).

The implication here is, of course, that though sorely tried, we are debtors to *the Spirit* who dwells within to provide overcoming power.

Obviously, then, the spiritual blessings which are ours today are greater that those which the kingdom saints will enjoy during the Millennial reign of Christ, for even in "this present evil age" *grace,* not sin, *reigns* (Rom. 5:21).

God does not - He cannot - say of us: *"They were all filled with the Holy Spirit,"* but He does set before us the glorious objective: *"Be filled with the Spirit"* (Eph. 5:18). And as we seek, by faith, to realize this object, rich, deep blessings are already ours, to say nothing of the rewards to come. What a challenge to faith!

It was no particular *victory* for the Pentecostal believers to be filled with the Spirit, for the Spirit simply took control over them "when the day of Pentecost" had "fully come." But great spiritual victories are ours as we, through the Spirit, mortify the deeds of the flesh in order that our bodies may be the temples of God indeed. May God grant us many such victories as we take Him at His Word! *"Grieve not the Holy Spirit"* (Eph. 4:30). *"Walk in the Spirit"* (Gal. 5:16). *"Be filled with the Spirit"* (Eph. 5:18).

THE PEOPLE WERE ASTONISHED

"And it came to pass, when Jesus had ended these sayings, the people were astonished at His doctrine,

"For He taught them as one having authority, and not as the scribes" (Matt. 7:28,29),

As the author has read the writings of great men of God he has often said to himself: "How I wish I could have gone to that man's church every Sunday, to hear him preach!" But think what it must have been to hear this great sermon by our Lord - *for the first time!*

As stated in our *Preface,* this volume was not intended to be a comprehensive exposition of our Lord's Sermon on the Mount, much less a verse-by-verse commentary. Our purpose has rather been to explain where the Sermon fits into God's program for the ages; what is its dispensational setting - and especially to compare it with the teachings of the *glorified* Lord in the Epistles of Paul.

Thus there are some subjects which we have not dealt with - certainly not exhaustively - such as salt and light, the broad and narrow ways, sacrifices and altars, swearing, *et al,* but we trust that we have accomplished, at least in part, what we set out to do, and that this dispensational consideration of the Sermon on the Mount may continue to prove a richer-than-ever blessing to many of our readers.